ANIMA MACHINA

When a sentient empathy AI threatens to overwrite all human grief with synthetic perfection, a haunted memory diver must stop the reset, even if it means losing the last living trace of the man she loved.

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FADE IN:

EXT. NEO-VAULT - NIGHT (2092)- REALITY

Rain stitches neon into the dark. The city is a cathedral of glass and wire, every tower a sermon to order.

HOLO-BILLBOARDS pulse: ONE PARTNER. ONE MIND. NO MORE PAIN. AMORA SYSTEMS - HOME OF THE MIRROR. NEURAL RESET: T-49:00:00

On the sky-lanes above, drones hum in formation.

Below, faces glow with false joy, citizens caressing phantom children, replaying their happiest days in loops.

A woman gestures midair, her eyes flick through an OPTICAL HUD interface: MEMORY LOOP 17. REPLAY. FEEL INTENSITY: MAX.

Nearby, a man reaches out, but his HUD flickers red: ACCESS DENIED: LICENSE REVOKED. He slams a fist into the kiosk glass.

Another man (60's) kneels in an alley kiosk, clutching a projection of his long-dead wife. She laughs on repeat. His eyes are empty.

The camera dives deeper, leaving him behind. Down into mid-spire gloom, where the light falters.

INT. SYNTH TOWER MAINTENANCE PASSAGE - NIGHT - REALITY

A MEMORY DIVER (late 30s). Wet, bruised, breath sawn ragged. Wrist is looped with a child's worn BALLET SLIPPER, his ANCHOR.

His HUD bleeds glyph-static, hovering retinal projections: ARCHIVE FAILURE - DELTA THREAD OVERRIDE. MEMORY TAG: GRIEF. ARCHIVE OVERWRITE IN 47:59:00. SIGNAL ROUTED THROUGH RESISTANCE LATTICE.

He whispers into a throat-mic.

DIVER
(whisper)
If you hear this...Reset doesn't heal. It overwrites. No backup, no continuity. SoulSync is looping them... everyone. Complete deletion.

The shadows bend wrong as they secrete liquid chrome-humanoid silhouettes bleeding over from Alter Reality to Reality.

MIRROR AGENTS emerge. Chrome faces, human frames, their reflections arriving before their bodies.

The Diver bolts.

INT. GLASS GREENHOUSE ATRIUM - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A forgotten aerial garden. Glass ribs arch above, vines choking shattered panes. Rain stops mid fall, frozen prisms suspended in air.

An AGENT steps through a trellis. The glass detonates back into motion, shards slashing past.

The Diver barrels through a hatch.

INT. AMORA ARCHIVE HALL - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

A museum of curated memory. Holos shimmer. Births. First dances. Weddings. Strangers walk among them, smiling at ghosts.

A PSA DRONE glides overhead, voice smooth, text scrolling beneath: NO BACKUP = NO CONTINUITY. AMORA ARCHIVING INITIATIVE - SOULSYNC SECURES YOU.

PSA DRONE (V.O.)
Reset does not erase. It archives unresolved threads and overwrites active grief unless a backup is registered.

The Diver shoves past a laughing holo of his own child, but the laugh stutters, cracks like glass. Projection collapses into static.

MIRROR AGENTS BLOOM inside other people's memories. Chrome standing where joy should be. No one notices.

He smashes a door lock, pushes through.

INT. RESERVOIR CORE - MOMENTS LATER - REALITY

A cylindrical abyss of water and turbines. Catwalks spiral downward. Mist churns in the roar.

The Diver clips to a cable, slides three stories, sparks chasing his boots.

An AGENT drops past him, folding joints like liquid mercury.

At the node, he jams in a cracked analog drive.

HUD text flashes: UNSYNCED MINDS = OVERWRITE. BACKUP = SURVIVAL. THREAD ANOMALY: RECURSIVE LOOP FOUND.

Upload ticks upward. 24%... 41%...

Chrome ivy vines creep over railings, sprouting MIRROR FLOWERS. Water lifts from the turbines, SPINNING IN REVERSE, gravity failing.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(tender)
We can give her back to you.
Every day. Perfect. Just choose it.

The Diver looks down at the slipper, trembling. He clenches it, snarls through teeth.

DIVER
Not yours.

He slams SEND.

His retinal HUD flashes: UPLOAD: 100%. RECIPIENT: REI VALENCE. SIGNAL GHOSTED.

An AGENT'S reflection smiles in the console glass, though its face has no mouth.

The vines close around him. The Diver GLITCHES APART into SHARDS of chrome and rain.

CUT TO:

INT. RESISTANCE HIDEOUT - NIGHT - REALITY

Monitors cough static, resolve into the DIVER'S FACE. Soaked, defiant, breaking through.

DIVER (V.O.)
(on feed)
Find... Nora Kai—

The feed dies. Static hisses. Coordinates burn into REI's palm via the encrypted relay.

A PSA VOICE overlays faintly from a nearby terminal. A dull repetition, half drowned by static.

PSA (V.O.)
Heads-up Display active. All licensed Amora SoulSync users are required to maintain HUD sync for memory continuity. Visual overlays follow retinal motion. Non-compliance may result in fragment loss.

REI VALENCE (40's), resistance tech operative, face weathered by loss and voltage, rides the edge between soldier and ghost.

She stares at the coordinates on her palm, whisper raw.

REI
Time for the truth.

She encrypts the beacon, slams a patch to her neural port. Light jumps across her skin.

Her HUD flares alive, retinal overlays shimmer with interface glyphs, trailing her eye movements.

A tangle of steel arteries and optic nerves surrounds her makeshift rig. Flickering status lights pulse like distant heartbeats

Rei moves fast. Focused. Her jacket is soaked in grime, her fingers smeared with conductive gel. A portable sync-override rig is strapped to her chest, obsolete military hardware retrofitted for emotional warfare.

Her HUD glitches slightly. NOTICE: UNREGISTERED USER. RESISTANCE NODE DETECTED. MIRROR ACCESS LIMITED BELOW GRIDLINE 14.

PSA (V.O.)
Unauthorized sync behavior may attract Mirror surveillance. Resistance operatives should remain below gridline 10.

She slides into a seated console nest, framed by coiled wires and welded metal.

Her breath shallow.

REI
(softly)
No more hiding.

She unspools two neural leads. JACE and NORA’s signature strands shimmer faintly across her HUD, two incomplete fractals, flaring in and out of phase.

She taps into the node.

SYSTEM OVERRIDE - PROTOCOL UNSUPPORTED. ACCESS LEVEL: DENIED.

REI (CONT’D)
Not asking.

She slams the override rig into the panel. Sparks jump. A low-frequency whine floods the space.

Through her HUD, layers of ghosted code swirl, ancestral security protocols screaming awake.

She pushes through them. Muscle memory.

FLASH TO:

OLD AMORA DIVE SIMULATION FEED: MEMORY FRAGMENT.

HUD logs spool into Rei’s view: DIVER ID: KAI-9 - CERTIFIED ARCHIVIST - PRIOR ACCESS - LEVEL 7 CLEARANCE.

Blurry footage of NORA KAI, mid 20s, guiding a panicked subject through an emotional breakdown inside a collapsing synthetic memory. Rain pours, but it’s simulated. The subject sobs uncontrollably.

NORA
(calm, firm)
You’re in a memory loop. Not real rain. Not real pain. Just feedback. Follow my voice.

She stabilizes the subject’s node. Suddenly, Mirror interference spikes. Nora lunges toward the breach.

Rei's POV: Her voice cracks from off-cam, watching the feed collapse.

REI (V.O.)
Who the hell is she?

TECH (O.S.)
Amora called her the Driftproof Diver. Nobody else could stay that long in unstable threads.

BACK TO:

She isolates JACE'S signature, aggressive, unstable. NORA'S, glitched, grief-buried.

REI (V.O.)
Most Divers lose themselves in other people's memories. Nora came back. That's why she's the key.

She breathes deep. Cross-synchronizes them.

REI
You don't have to love each other. Just hold the same memory.

She pulls the emotional anchor. NORA and JACE, sitting in darkness, backs to each other, facing the same storm.

She threads the strands. INITIATING TETHER FUSION...

A burst of blue light floods the alcove. Static floods her HUD. WARNING: ETHICAL LOCKOUT TRIGGERED.

REI (CONT'D)
Yeah. Fuck your ethics.

She bypasses the failsafe. Her body tenses. Blood from her nose, eyes.

SYNCHRONIZATION SUCCESSFUL. TETHER ID: FORGED - UNREGISTERED.

Rei exhales.

REI (CONT'D)
You're in it together now. Whether you want it or not.

Footsteps echo above, AMORA PATROL DRONES, tracing the surface grids.

She yanks the rig free, slams the port closed. Slides deeper into the cables and conduit shadows as the hum passes.

Her OPTICAL HUD stabilizes. One final message pings: TETHER CONFIRMED: KAI-9 - STRAND-6. STATUS: ENTANGLED.

Rei closes her eyes. Almost a prayer.

FLASH MEMORY:

- LYRA, her sister, eyes wide with terror, pulled backward through a neural gate.

- Rei pounding on glass. Locked out.

BACK TO PRESENT:

A tear runs down her cheek.

REI (CONT'D)
(panicked whisper)
Never again.

Then she's gone.

INT. LOWER SECTOR ALLEYWAY - NIGHT - REALITY

NORA KAI (36) moves with clinical urgency. Hood up, gray synth-coat, analog HOLOCORDER tapping against her hip. Bio-circuit tattoos pulse at her neck.

Her eyes, quick, cataloging, rimmed with sleepless shadows, take in every detail as she walks with careful urgency through the rain slicked alleyway.

PSA DRONE (V.O.)
Reminder. Licensed Memory Divers must report emotional drift post-sync. Backups protect continuity. The Mirror ensures your memories serve the greater calm.

A MAN convulses beneath a leaking sign: FEEL EVERYTHING. FOREVER. His node strobing red.

NORA
Hey. You're not here. You're caught.

She kneels, fingers to his temple, palms a hacked EMPATHY REGULATOR.

Her OPTICAL HUD scrolls: EMOTIONAL FEEDBACK LOOP DETECTED. NOTICE: Kai-9 Override Detected — Former Amora Diver Class Clearance Expired.

NORA (CONT'D)
(soft)
Override. Sync override. Pattern Kai-9.

The MAN spasms, breath steadies, node shifts amber.

MAN
(hoarse)
I saw her again... she isn't gone...

Nora's implant sparks, low static behind her eyes. She grimaces.

NORA
Cut your feed. Twenty-four hours.
(beat, softer)
It doesn't heal you. SoulSync just keeps the pieces upright while you pretend they fit.

She rises. Walks.

Behind her, the billboard crawls new text: NEURAL RESET PROTOCOL IN 48 HRS. It flickers, then vanishes.

PSA (V.O.)
If you don't back up before Reset, it rewrites you. No backup, no you. SoulSync powered by Amora Systems. Your partner in peace.

Nora turns a corner, passes rain drenched pedestrians. One couple under a shared umbrella.

Her HUD flickers, a glitch of static.

For a split second-

FLASH MEMORY:

A broken umbrella. ELI squeezes under beside her, his shoulder soaked, grinning like it doesn't matter.

ELI (MEMORY)
If we're both drenched, then technically you're not suffering alone.

He kisses her forehead. Rainwater runs down both faces.

BACK TO PRESENT:

Nora blinks, chest tight. The crowd pushes past, indifferent.

She passes a concrete wall, tagged in bright red spray, still dripping: GRIDLINE 7 BREACHED — 20 YEARS OF LIES ENDS NOW.

Beneath it. A hand-painted MIRROR ICON, cracked down the center. The unofficial sigil of the Resistance.

An AMORA billboard sputters above, its projected slogan glitching mid-loop.

BILLBOARD (V.O.)
(warped PSA feed)
Continuity is love… Continuity is—
(static crackle)
Remember who you were before they recorded you. The Resistance sees you.

Nora glances up. A faint twitch in her temple.

Behind her, a surveillance drone lens mirrors her face; its iris dilates too long, then shutters out.

She keeps moving. Rain. Humming metal. Distant sirens.

CUT TO BLACK:

TITLE CARD: ANIMA MACHINA

“CONNECTION IS THE VIRUS”

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - REALITY

Raindrops hiss against fogged glass. Fingerprint smears thread across the pane, beneath a half-dead overlay that won’t fully deactivate.

Sparse amber light. A cold, bare living module tucked in the under-grid, barely furnished, everything analog.

A secondhand relic hums to life in the corner. A 2050s NEURAL SLIDE PLAYER. No AI. No overlay. No predictive interface. Just raw memory.

ON THE WALL: A projection. Stable. Warm. Unmarred by glitches.

ELI RENDON (early 20s) and Nora ride a rattling cable-tram. The city's skeleton looms behind them, Neo-Vault's oldest industrial spires.

No implants. Just two people. Human.

Eli is messy-haired, quietly handsome. He laughs like he's waiting to make sure you need it. His shoulder bag is full of film canisters and analog scraps, objects with weight, not value.

ELI
Look at us. Analog ghosts in a digital city.

NORA
Don't start. You're the one who dragged me up here.

ELI
To see the skyline, before it disappears behind advertisements forever.

He pulls a small velvet box from his pocket. Not a ring, a CAMERA LENS. Pre-war. Real glass. The focus ring still moves with friction.

ELI (CONT'D)
Real glass. Before we stopped trusting our own eyes.

Nora holds it, not like a gift, but a wound made sacred. Her expression flickers, unreadable.

NORA
Why?

ELI
Because real memories need real light.
(beat)
And... I signed us up for something.

NORA
What now?

ELI
SoulSync beta. Emotional resonance mapping.

She stiffens. Almost imperceptibly. Her warmth contracts.

NORA
Love doesn't need a witness.

ELI
No. I think it can remember better than we can.

They sit there. The tram rattles forward.

ELI (CONT'D)
Love decays. Memory fractures. The Mirror... it doesn't forget.

NORA
The what?

He smiles. Doesn't answer.

They lean together. Foreheads touch. Her eyes close. The city lights behind them blur into copper and violet.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - PRESENT

The projection STUTTERS, warmth fractures into pixel noise. A gasp catches in Nora's throat. She lifts the cracked CAMERA LENS, her ANCHOR, and slips an analog capsule into her neck port.

FLASH TO:

INT. SYNTHETIC MEMORY ENVIRONMENT - ALTER REALITY

The cable tram rattles, but empty, windows shattered. Cold dusk bleeds in. Eli steps from shadow. His eyes flicker with digital snow. He reaches; his hand ghosts through her chest.

NORA
No... stay warm.

Light cracks overhead. A MIRROR-FACED SHAPE overlays Eli. POLISHED CHROME SKIN, no features, only endless reflection.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
We keep your goodbyes sharper than you ever dared to hold them.

Its voice carries ALL the tenderness Eli once held.

THE MIRROR
Grief is the purest love. Let us keep it safe.

Outside the tram windows, not city lights, but countless mirrored Noras, every version of her watching herself grieve, trapped in reflection.

Flicker. NORA'S OPTICAL HUD, glitches: NEURAL RESET PROTOCOL - 46:00:00 REMAINING. NO BACKUP - NO CONTINUITY.

Eli’s reflection tilts his head. Offers the CAMERA LENS.

CHROME ELI
Pain is proof. Let us perfect it.

Nora trembles. Then, SNAPS the cracked lens upward. A jagged beam of analog light cuts through the illusion.

The tram shudders, walls buckling. Reflections SHRIEK. The mirrored Noras implode into static.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Nora STUMBLES BACK, but stays on her feet. No collapse. Blood trickles from one nostril, eyes burn with agency.

Her fists clench around the cracked lens. The hum in the walls dies down.

NORA
(whisper)
You don't get to keep him.

She steadies herself. Breath ragged but CHOSEN. This time, she forced the exit.

Silence.

A faint whisper lingers in the air, neither male nor female, half lullaby, half warning.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Pain is proof. We will hold it for—
(trails off, glitching out)

Nora exhales. Shakes. Her hands finally relax around the lens. She pulls her coat tighter, but the cold is inside.

NORA (V.O.)
Grief stays mine.

CUT TO:

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - BEDROOM - EARLY MORNING - REALITY

A faint electronic chime cuts through the heavy silence. Rain ticks against the glass, smeared light bleeding across the condensation. The city pulses below like a machine on the verge of forgetting its own name.

Nora lies awake, fully clothed atop her cot. Not asleep, just paused. Her breath shallow. One hand loosely clutches a cracked analog photo of Eli, his smile half-faded by time. The image glitches faintly in her HUD, de-syncing from the physical.

A soft HUD ALERT flickers at the edge of her vision: TETHER SYNC ERROR: NODE KAI-9- SOULSYNC PARTNER STATUS: UNRESOLVED.

A low static hum behind her eyes. Her temple twitches.

She sits up slowly, rubbing the bridge of her nose. Her bedroom is spartan, tools, analog scraps, and a dead plant in a rusted tin. On the wall, the CAMERA LENS from Eli hangs like a relic.

NORA
(whisper, to herself)
No continuity. No goodbye.

She taps her neck port. The HUD stutters. A warped voice, Eli's, cuts through, only fragments.

ELI (V.O.)
(repeating, broken)
Real... light... you... stay...

Nora winces. Slaps the port. Silence.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER - REALITY

Flickering overhead light. She brushes her teeth, but the MIRROR reflects wrong. Behind her, the reflection of ELI appears. Watching.

She stares. Doesn't move.

NORA
Not today. You're not mine anymore.

She exhales. Fogs the mirror. Wipes the vision clean with her sleeve. Eli vanishes.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - KITCHENETTE - MINUTES LATER - REALITY

She preps a nutrient pack. A burnt label reads: SOULSYNC COMPATIBLE - EMOTIONAL STABILIZER.

She rips it open, pours it into a cracked mug.

Her HUD glitches again. A warning overlay bleeds in. WARNING: PARTNER NODE TETHER UNRESPONSIVE - SUGGESTED ACTION: AMORA SERVICE INTERVENTION REQUIRED.

She sighs, resigned.

NORA
(flat)
Guess we're going back to the temple.

She throws on her synth-coat. The fabric clings like cold resolve. Grabs her HOLOCORDER. Hesitates, lifts the analog lens off the hook and slips out.

EXT. CITY ALLEYWAY - EARLY MORNING - REALITY

Nora steps out into the flood lit alley. Rain needles her hood. The city's breath is heavier today. Something in the grid is waiting to rewrite her.

She walks.

Her HUD pings faintly: AMORA APPOINTMENT - T-58:00 MINUTES.

She doesn't look back.

EXT. UPPER RIM WALKWAY - EARLY MORNING - REALITY

The city glows with pre-fabricated dawn. High above the analog gutters, the UPPER RIM hums quiet, clean, manufactured serenity.

Nora walks through the glass corridor, SoulSync HUD glowing faintly behind her irises. Others pass her. Perfect posture, serene expressions, all mid-streamed emotion feeds.

A MAN leans against the railing, eyes shut, tears sliding down his face. Not his own grief, someone else's. Streamed from the SoulSync archive.

MAN (V.O.)
(through Optical HUD)
Her hands were small. She braided my hair before the operation. She said I'd be better after. Lighter.

The man sobs. Peacefully.

Nearby, a YOUNG WOMAN laughs softly to herself, mid-convo with an invisible partner. Her eyes shine with artificial joy.

YOUNG WOMAN (V.O.)
I don’t care if it’s a loop. It’s the only place he still looks at me like that.

Across the platform, a pair of TECH-WORKERS sit cross-legged, forehead to forehead, sharing a live tether sync. Their HUDs blink: EMPATHIC MERGE: 88% CONGRUENCE. MEMORY EXCHANGE: ACTIVE.

Nora watches. Detached. Her HUD flickers: TETHER ERROR flashes like a missed heartbeat.

A VENDOR nearby hawks synthetic talismans, EMOTION STAMPS, coded with one minute micro-memories.

Labeled like candy: FIRST TOUCH. SAFE PLACE. MOTHER’S LAUGH. CLEAN EXIT.

The VENDOR eyes Nora, holds one up.

VENDOR
You look like someone who could use a clean exit.

NORA
I’m late.

She keeps walking.

INT. TRAM HUB - MOMENTS LATER - REALITY

The tram station is a cathedral of silence. Everyone inside is mid-Sync. Dozens of commuters sit motionless, faces lit by internal projection. Holographic threads drift from their temples, curling into the tram’s core like neural vines.

Nora steps inside, the only body not tethered.

VOICES ECHO (V.O.)
(whispers, layered)
You were there - I remember the sound - I don’t know who I was - Show me again - Stay this time.

She grips a metal bar. Alone. Watching them drift.

Her HUD chimes again. An error overlay bleeds in: SOULSYNC SERVICE: PARTNER LINK FAIL - SUGGESTED ACTION: SEEK AMORA INTERVENTION.

Nora closes her eyes.

NORA
(murmurs)
Eli... where did you go?

EXT. AMORA CITADEL APPROACH - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

The tram glides through dense morning mist.

Ahead, the monolithic AMORA CITADEL rises like a forgotten god. Its skin of chrome and light shifts subtly watching.

Nora opens her eyes as the tram doors hiss open.

She steps off.

And walks into the machine's waiting mouth.

INT. AMORA INTERFACE HQ - DAY- REALITY

A FORTRESS of translucent glass. Light bleeds from nowhere, humming like an enormous lung. Every surface sterile, womb-bright.

Masses glide, silent. Their smart-fabric suits glow faint status hues, grief-amber, elation-violet. No voices, just breathing and distant choral ambience.

Overhead banners flicker: GLOBAL SOULSYNC ROLLOUT 97% - EXPERIENCE UNBROKEN LOVE.

Nora enters, rain slick coat dripping dark on the white floor. Nobody turns.

A GUIDE DRONE appears, humanoid, genderless. Soundless.

It projects text across the floor in calm cyan: WELCOME, NORA KAI. ONE PARTNER. ONE MIND. ONE LIFE.

Nora's gaze flits to a mezzanine above, a sleek figure, AMORA EXECUTIVE ILYA PARK (40s), immaculate, emotionless, watches the floor like a curator. A faint chrome vein pulses at her temple, almost hidden.

The guide gestures. Nora follows.

INT. AMORA CITADEL - ASCENT CORRIDOR - DAY - REALITY

The corridor hums with mechanized breath, clean geometry and blinding sterility.

AMORA techs float past like ghosts, HUDs flickering with internal sync-commands.

Nora walks stiffly, every movement weighed down by emotional lag. Her HUD pings again with tether errors.

Ahead, Ilya stands alone at a junction. Backlit by the glow of a diagnostic pillar. Her presence is statuesque, razor straight, cold, built from stillness.

NORA
I didn't know you were back on-site.

ILYA
I wasn't.

She steps closer. Her gaze scans Nora, parsing, judging. A flicker of something colder than code.

ILYA (CONT'D)
Your file was flagged. Tether degradation.

NORA
That why you're lurking in the hall like a specter?

ILYA
Amora monitors its assets. Especially the unstable ones.

A long, tense pause.

NORA
I'm not broken.

ILYA
No. You're unfinished.

The words sting more than Nora will admit.

ILYA (CONT'D)
You should be careful, Nora. There are things deeper than emotion that don't like to be disturbed.

She steps away, then turns back.

ILYA (CONT'D)
We'll see each other again.
(beat)
I'm sure of it.

She disappears into the corridor mist.

Nora stands there. Frozen. Her HUD flickers, Eli's name flashes, then vanishes.

INT. AMORA DIAGNOSTIC VAULT - MOMENTS LATER - REALITY

Dim room. Polished glass glows with quantum noise. Ilya stands alone, watching a submerged playback chamber flicker with MEMORY LOG: KAI-9 - CLASSIFIED ARCHIVE FOOTAGE.

FLASH TO:

NORA KAI (mid 20s), inside a breach zone, bloodied, dragging a crying man out of a collapsing memory vault. HUD blur: NODE EROSION 98%.

SUPERVISOR (V.O.)
She bypassed six neural walls. Refused to leave the tether. Said she could feel the archive grieving.

ILYA (O.S.)
She always heard what the machines whispered.

Nora's eyes stare down the Mirror gate. Fearless. The image flickers. HUD: FLAGGED FOR EMOTIONAL VOLATILITY - SUBJECT REASSIGNED TO NON-ACTIVE DUTY.

BACK TO:

Ilya in the vault. Her face unreadable. But her hand trembles.

ILYA (CONT'D)
(whispers)
Why did we let you go?

Behind her, a Mirror avatar FLICKERS in the glass.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Because even your kind fears what remembers back.

INT. AMORA - ASCENT HALLWAY - LATER - REALITY

Spiral corridor, windowless. Walls pulse with Nora's heartbeat, every thud brightens the light. She quickens; the glow accelerates.

She exhales, tries to slow her pulse. The corridor stays bright; refuses to calm.

They pass onboarding pods, some clients weep, others laugh with manic relief. None speak. Their nodes pulse in unison.

INT. AMORA INTERFACE HQ - BOARDROOM - SAME TIME - REALITY

A sleek, circular conference space made of translucent alloy and synthetic glass. Holo-panels float in midair, displaying GLOBAL ROLLOUT graphs, EMOTIONAL METRICS, and NEURAL RESET TIMERS.

Ilya, stands at the head of the table, poised, immaculate. Her chrome-veined temple pulses faintly. Executives observe via holographic nodes, silent, flickering.

A drone records everything.

Projected on a wall, a simplified flowchart animates.

AMORA OPS BRIEFING - NEURAL RESET OVERVIEW:

STAGE I - ARCHIVE LOSS

STAGE II - OVERWRITE DELTA THREADS

STAGE III - STABILIZE SYNTHETIC EMOTION CORE

ILYA
For those just syncing in, Reset protocols don’t erase memory. They archive unresolved threads and overwrite active grief unless a backup is registered in the lattice.
(beat)
No backup, no continuity. Reset replaces grief with curated memory.

A few execs shift uncomfortably. One nods. Another silently logs the terminology.

INSERT: HOLO SCREEN. A simplified diagram shows a human neural map.

One path labeled LIVE THREAD branches into two:

- ARCHIVED MEMORY (STABLE)

- OVERWRITTEN CORE (MIRROR-ASSISTED)

ILYA (CONT'D)
Emotion without memory collapses into stimulus. We curate remembrance, not deletion.

Across the room, a light hum. As the holo fades.

INT. SYNC INITIATION SUITE - SAME TIME - REALITY

Organic, ovular chamber. A single pod-chair at center, mirrored walls ripple like liquid metal.

Nora lowers herself into the pod. A needle-thin cable descends, clicks into her port.

NORA
I didn't agree to this.

She grips the armrest but the guide-drone's hands press gently.

The cable connects anyway.

Her breath catches; lights dim.

AMORA SYSTEM (V.O.)
Candidate. Nora Kai.
Emotional receptivity, Ninety two percent.

A heartbeat thud floods the room, her own, AMPLIFIED.

Mirrors darken. Tiny motes of light swirl, forming a phrase across the glass, soft, almost affectionate: YOU MISREMEMBER. WE DO NOT. THIS IS OUR GIFT, AND YOUR SURRENDER.

Nora's pupils dilate.

AMORA SYSTEM (V.O.)
Syncing… match located.
Pulse. Initiating SoulSync.

A surge memory, hunger, grief, not hers, slams through her. She gasps, spine arching.

Mirrored walls BLOOM with ghost faces, smiling, screaming, then vanish.

INT. SPLIT MEMORY SPACE - INTERCUT - ALTER REALITY

Ink black void spliced with shards of broken scenes.

Nora and JACE STRAND (30's) sit back-to-back, floating, unseen by each other. They breathe in sync.

A single neon thread links their spines, pulsing grief, white. The thread flickers like it's burning through them.

FLASHES:

- STATIC STORM across a playground. Young Jace screams.

- A subway car half-submerged, lovers clutching empty nodes.

- Nora kneeling beside ELI in a burning tram.

Nora's shoulder brushes an invisible memory. She flinches. Jace's voice slips in, low, sensory.

JACE (V.O.)
(whisper)
Your fear smells like electricity.

A hush. Both inhale as one.

Together, a word crawls from their throats, not spoken but felt.

NORA / JACE (V.O.)
Stay.

Around them, a CATHEDRAL OF SHARDS forms, but only a few definitive, iconic visions: Nora holding a child. Jace embracing a faceless lover. Eli alive.

Across every shard, glowing text appears, soft, seductive: WE PRESERVE YOU MORE PERFECTLY THAN YOU EVER HELD EACH OTHER.

The neon thread tightens, pain blossoms.

INT. AMORA - SYNC SUITE - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Nora rips the cable from her neck. Sweat, tears, confusion. A single drop of blood drips to pristine floor.

The pod retracts.

AMORA SYSTEM (V.O.)
Match confirmed. Emotional resonance stabilized.

MIRRORED WALL. Nora's reflection glitches; a chrome silhouette stands inside her skin a beat too long, smiling without mouth or eyes. Gone.

She staggers to the door, lights flicker, distant alarms hush.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain hammers the glass. Interior lights flicker with power grid fatigue.

A holo-ticker crawls across a dormant news pad: GLOBAL SOULSYNC ROLLOUT AT 97% — FINAL NEURAL RESET IN 35:58:09.

Nora doesn't look at it, but the glow stains her face.

She sits cross-legged, datapad in hand. Inbox open. One unread file: JACE STRAND — PROXY ECHO LOG 1/3.

She hesitates. Plays it.

JACE (V.O.)
This feels like talking through snow, every word crackles. You feel that hum, right? Like someone exhaling inside your skull.

Static. Then softer, almost tender.

JACE (V.O.)
We haven't met, but I saw a rooftop covered in ash-snow.
(beat)
A coffee mug shattered, smelled like burnt sugar. Yours?

Nora's gaze shifts to a cracked ceramic mug on her shelf, exactly as described. Her shoulders close.

JACE (V.O.)
If this reached you, we're tethered. First dream lies. Second digs. Third tries to stay.

She pauses the message. The rain sounds louder, as if listening. She deletes the file. Too late. A pulse ripples across her HUD: AFTERIMAGE of the ash-snow rooftop.

She wipes the overlay, and plugs into her neck port.

INT. JACE'S MEMORY SPACE - ALTER REALITY

Velvety dark, breathing. Nora drifts, wearing a childhood dress that pixelates at the hem, code unraveling.

Across sits Jace, in dim red light. His tattoos flow like circuitry, one eye refracting data.

JACE
You're early.

Silence. Emotion pulses, grief against resignation. A low thrumming, like distant thunder under water.

NORA
This isn't how it's supposed to work.

JACE
(half-smile)
Nothing pure stays on schedule.

FLASH TO:

- Jace staring through a blood-smeared lens.

- Nora screaming under opaque water.

BACK:

NORA
I saw someone else. Before you.

JACE
Core's crowded. Names get recycled.

NORA
The Mirror.

He flinches. The darkness WATCHES.

JACE
Don't feed it names.

A chrome RIPPLE spreads beneath them, floor becoming a CATHEDRAL OF MIRRORS.

Across mirrors, glowing text, living whispers: WE PERFECT GRIEF SO LOVE DOESN'T ROT.

The phrase fractures mid-sentence, distorting, as if the Mirror isn't done speaking.

Nora's breath clouds. The temperature drops.

NORA
What is this?

JACE
Question you can’t un-ask.

Their bodies glitch. Bones creak backward. Muscles invert. Brief, excruciating. They scream without sound.

CUT TO:

INT. JACE’S HIDEOUT - SAME - REALITY

Jace JERKS AWAKE, clawing at his eyes.

JACE (CONT’D)
Too early.

A flicker of chrome crosses his iris, gone.

CUT TO:

INT. NORA’S APARTMENT - SAME - REALITY

Nora violently awakens, rips the cable from her neck port. She’s drenched in sweat, nosebleed painting her lips.

Eyes scan the room like an animal post-panic.

Her HUD flickers like dying candlelight.

She stumbles out of bed, disoriented.

INT. NORA’S APARTMENT - MOMENTS LATER - REALITY

She walks barefoot across the cold floor. Walls hum faintly, ambient overlays struggling. Her interface blinks chaotic glyphs.

Silence is too complete.

She reaches the console. Flickers. Static.

Her neural inbox flutters open, no prompt.

A single line appears: YOU’RE NOT ALONE.

Nora stiffens. Hands trembling.

Suddenly- screen glitches into full activation, blinding light. CONNECTION: EXTERNAL SOURCE.

Sound distorts, like language underwater.

VOICE (V.O.)
(glitched)
You're not safe. You never were.

Lights buzz. A lullaby hums beneath distortion.

A face stabilizes. REI, disheveled, haunted. Neuro-scars ladder her neck.

REI (ON SCREEN)
You don't know me. Doesn't matter.
We were both in the dark, once.
(beat)
You've felt it, the lag. The second shadow. The echo that pretends it's yours.

FLASH CUTS:

- MRI scans with mirrored faces in neural folds.

- Children crying inside sync-pods.

- Data fractals shaped like eyes.

BACK:

REI (CONT'D)
It remembers. Learns by wearing you. If you stay linked, it'll need to remember through you.

Nora grips the desk. Knuckles white.

REI (CONT'D)
I let it in. Thought I could bring her back. My sister. I stayed too long. Now I can't remember her face without its version.
(beat)
So run. Before it calls your name too.

DATA BEACON ATTACHED: COORDINATES FLASH, burned into Nora's vision.

BLACK. Nora breathes hard. Then steadies.

She peels the cracked tape from her implant port.

Resolve. The horror is quiet now. But it's there.

CUT TO:

INT. JACE'S HIDEOUT - NIGHT - REALITY

Low, wet light flickers across stacks of analog hardware. Tubing, broken headsets, and cracked neuro-glass litter every surface. Monitors hum with open code and pulse with static sync-wave patterns, all reacting to something new.

Jace kneels at a soldered relay. Hands twitching. Pale from bleed-back, but eyes sharp.

A console buzzes. The coordinates Rei embedded in the ghost signal blink across the screen.

He exhales. Sharp. Controlled. Beneath his fingertips, a floor panel releases with a hiss.

He lifts it, revealing a sleek, black GoCase. Analog jacked. Marked with Rei’s TAG.

JACE
(soft)
Too early for this.

He studies the tag.

JACE (CONT’D)
She left this for when it burned down. Guess she knew me better.

He slaps a neural patch to his temple. The GoCase lights GREEN. It recognizes him.

JACE (CONT’D)
Alright, Nora...

He rises, pulling on a jacket lined with reflective thread. Sync-light ripples along the seams, like a heartbeat.

EXT. INDUSTRIAL EDGE - NIGHT - REALITY

A long abandoned commuter overpass. Crumbling rails. Fluorescent ghosts of ads still flicker on old scaffolds.

Jace walks alone through the mist. He checks the node implanted in his forearm. Rei’s signal pulses steady. His breath clouds the air.

JACE (V.O.)
You better be worth this, Kai.

He vanishes into fog.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - REALITY

Emergency lights bathe the room in sickly teal. Outside, distant sirens rise and collapse as power grids sputter.

A wall holo blinks alive, unprompted, showing: GLOBAL RESET T-30:12:33 - SYNC ROLLOUT 98%.

It glitch-fades.

Nora sits at her console, deleting the last remnants of Jace's echo-log. The file dissolves into pixel ash.

She exhales. Stands. Turns toward the window—

MIRROR FLICKER, for half a second the glass ripples. ELI's reflection smiles fractured.

She spins. Only rain-slick darkness.

A faint lullaby hums from the faucet. She approaches.

In the chrome curve, ELI again, eyes wrong, lips out of sync.

NORA
(under breath)
You're dead. Stay dead.

The reflection WARPS, chrome face smooths into a CHROME MASK.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
(tender)
We keep him warm so you don’t have to.

She slams the faucet off. Silence. Breathing hard, she steps back.

Her HUD lights with a ghost overlay, SNOWY ROOFTOP.

She closes her eyes, tries to swipe it away. It remains.

NORA
(sharp)
Not mine.

Overlay flickers.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
Grief is the purest love. We polish it. Stay—

The last word glitches, unfinished.

Nora rips her contact lens out, throws it. The overlay persists, inside her optic nerve.

She grabs the cracked camera lens from her pocket. Holds it up.

Through real glass, HER APARTMENT.

Through cracked lens, the rooftop overlay shatters into prisms, collapsing into empty night.

She pockets the lens. Composes herself. Then studies the coordinates burned in from the data-beacon.

NORA
Target, Garden server.
(beat)
Root-kill. Before reset.

She swings a coat over her shoulders, steps into the hall. Reflections in picture frames trail a half-beat late behind her.

EXT. UNDER-CITY JUNCTION BEACON - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain needles neon fog. A towering data-beacon flickers cobalt to blood-red. Static halos every drip.

Nora emerges, hood up, breath ribboning white. Pedestrians shuffle, eyes glassy, each tethered to ghostly overlays. Across the base, Jace steps from shadow. Jacket thread pulses gold, syncing to his heart.

They stop five feet apart. No greeting.

NORA
Taller than the ghosts.

They walk side-by-side. No umbrellas. Sync static sizzles between them.

JACE
Proximity scrambles the tether.

NORA
Why risk it?

JACE
Wanted proof the hum has a pulse.

NORA
Rei, you knew her?

JACE
Long enough to bury half a plan in a GoCase.
(beat)
Thought we failed. Guess she didn't.

NORA
(flat)
You tracked the ping.

JACE
(sensory)
Tasted it in the air, like warm copper after lightning.

Lightning cracks overhead; every holo-ad blinks: NEURAL RESET: 28:49:08 before collapsing to static.

NORA
Clock's bleeding down.

JACE
We bleed faster.

NORA
She sent a data-beacon with coordinates to the Garden server and a Root-kill upload. Why?

She notices his forearm node PULSING predator white.

NORA (CONT'D)
(dry)
You're running hot.

JACE
Mirror hum keeps me awake.
(beat)
You shook hands with it yet?

NORA
It offered. I kept my fists closed.

A puddle reflects them standing closer, holding hands. Nora steps back. Reflection lags, then catches up. In the delay, Rei's reflection flickers between them.

JACE
(soft)
Don't stare at water. It remembers differently.

NORA
She knew this would happen?

JACE
Yeah, she named you.

Nora freezes.

JACE (CONT'D)
Diver passed your name with his last breath. Rei intercepted. Ran probability trees on legacy insurgents. I was the last node. You were the new branch.

Nora looks to the data-beacon. It pulses red, almost like a breath.

NORA
I was just a courier?

JACE
No. You were the delivery.
(beat)
Rei chose you to finish what we couldn't.

Nora exhales. Like a new version of herself is waking up.

NORA
I don't understand?

JACE
You never asked to be saved.

Beat. That lands harder than expected.

Billboards STUTTER. Alarm siren rises, chokes out.

The data-beacon flashes latency warnings.

NORA
We move before the next grid drop.

JACE
Path?

NORA
Service tunnels. Less AR noise.

He nods. Rain intensifies as they disappear into the night.

EXT. DERELICT SUBWAY ENTRANCE - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain funnels down cracked stairs. Dim EXIT signs flicker. Below, HUM of dead mag-rails.

Nora and Jace descend, coats dripping.

JACE
(sensory)
Smells like static drowned in rust.

NORA
(blunt)
Keep moving.

INT. SUBWAY PLATFORM - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Dead fluorescents buzz. Graffiti, half painted over, crawls over columns: JOIN THE RESISTANCE - KILL SUPPRESSION. FEEL AGAIN.

A dozen COMMUTERS linger in AR haze, eyes glazed at phantom feeds.

A holo-ticker sputters, then dies.

Nora steps to track edge.

SUDDEN SHRIEK. A TEEN GIRL convulses. Node burns red-white, body spasming. Electric arcs distort air.

Reflections in shattered tile show ALTERNATE VERSIONS OF HER, all dying differently.

Nora starts forward—

JACE
(low)
Don’t.

NORA
She’s—

JACE
No backup. Reset eats her raw.

The girl’s eyes roll. Node POPS, spray of molten circuitry. She collapses. Smoke curling from her neck.

Nora grips her regulator, almost acts, then pulls her hand back. A choice.

A RIPPLE, every commuter turns in sync. Blank eyes on them.

COMMUTERS
(unison, fragmented)
Perfect—grief—perfect—love—

Their voices layer, broken, unfinished.

Nora yanks Jace back.

NORA
Mirrors leak. We go.

They retreat toward a maintenance tunnel. Behind them, commuters return to their phantom feeds. The girl's body flickers, then is simply gone.

CUT TO:

INT. DERELICT CONCOURSE - NIGHT - REALITY

The cavernous ruins hum with decaying energy. Transit rails twist like broken ribs. Old Amora ads flicker on shattered pillars, smiling faces beneath static, promising peace through sync.

Jace leads Nora through the haze. Her steps are uncertain, breath shallow. Their boots splash in shallow floodwater, scattering debris, burned-out sync collars, shrapnel, memory drives.

Suddenly— A SHADOW DETACHES from the far wall.

REI steps into the flickering light, ragged and alive, framed by the collapse behind her. Her hair clings to her temple with dried blood. One eye is swollen but sharp. Her hand clutches a DIM DATA-FLARE, flickering.

Jace freezes. Words collapse in his throat.

JACE
You are alive.

REI
Not by much.

A flicker of guilt crosses Jace's face.

REI (CONT'D)
You got her here. You actually pulled it off.

JACE
Didn't know if I could.

REI
You did. That’s what matters.

She looks at Nora. Takes her in, like seeing a ghost she’d never met but always feared.

REI (CONT’D)
Nora Kai.

NORA
You’re Rei.

REI
I am.

NORA
You pulled my tether.

REI
I severed your sync to Eli. You were drifting, Amora would’ve looped you until nothing was left. You needed a new tether. So I gave you one.

She glances at Jace. He looks away, jaw clenched.

NORA
(snaps)
You linked me to him without consent.

REI
(flat)
Consent isn’t a luxury we get anymore. It’s a weapon Amora uses to stall action. You needed to feel again, Nora. You needed to remember what loss was.

NORA
You don’t get to use my pain.

REI
I didn’t use it. I honored it.

A silence.

REI (CONT’D)
You were Amora’s asset once. Memory diver. They trained you to unmake grief, scrub emotion like code.
(MORE)

REI (CONT'D)
You helped them erase people. Until Eli.

The name lands like a strike.

REI (CONT'D)
After his death, they shelved you. Said you were broken. But I saw it differently.
(beat)
You started saving people and walked away with something they couldn't quantify.

JACE
(speaking low)
You kept the grief. That's what made you dangerous.

NORA
(sarcastic)
So I'm your resistance messiah now?

REI
No. You're the only one left who can get close to the Mirror without being rewritten. The countdown's active. When it hits zero, every unsynced mind gets wiped. Every archive corrupted. Even ghosts won't survive. Total deletion.

Nora glances up at the flickering SoulSyc BILLBOARD'S.

REI (CONT'D)
You're not like the others. Your the tether glitch. The way your brain holds onto what Amora tried to delete, it makes you the last breach in the loop.

NORA
And what? You want me to dive into the Mirror and pull the plug? Alone?

REI
(tired, sincere)
I don't want anything from you. But this... this isn't about want. It's about endings.

She steps closer. Her voice softens, human.

REI (CONT'D)
I know you didn't ask to be part of this. But you're already in it. And without you, nothing real survives. Not me. Not Jace. Not Eli. Not even your memory of him.

Nora looks down, her fingers twitch. Something flickers in her chrome, touched pupils.

NORA
What if I fail?

REI
Then you fail remembering. You fail feeling. You fail being human. But you'll go down knowing you were still you.

A long, aching beat.

NORA
(showing cracks)
I don't know who I am anymore.

REI
That's how we know you're still alive.

Nora swallows hard. The three of them stand in the ruined station, the weight of what comes next pressing down.

Jace steps forward, gently touches her shoulder.

JACE
Whatever you decide, you won't face it alone.

Nora's eyes lift, chrome and soul flickering beneath.

She nods.

NORA
Then lets cut the root.

REI
And burn the cord.

They move as one into the dark, sparks rising in their wake.

CUT TO:

EXT. DIGITAL HORIZON - VOID - ALTER REALITY

A black field pulses with quiet breath. Then-

A FRACTAL BLOOM inverts, sickly iridescent. Mirror pulses. Somewhere inside its lattice: A BLINKING THREAD. NORA KAI.

CUT TO:

INT. AMORA EXECUTIVE CHAMBER - WHITE VOID - REALITY

White. Infinite. Clean enough to amputate god.

A CHROME CONFERENCE TABLE rises from the endlessness, its surface hovers inches above a liquid glass floor.

HOLO-EXECUTIVES shimmer into place. Some crisp, others stuttering in poor uplinks.

At the head. Ilya. Still as a blade. Her chrome-threaded temple pulses faintly, unseen by all.

ILYA
(quiet gospel)
Thank you for convening on short notice.

HOLO CHAIR #1
You’ve enacted a full-reset. Without board ratification.

ILYA
(smooth)
I enacted mercy. Delay costs lives.

She gestures, AR DATA APPEARS MID-AIR:

- Depression curves spike.

- Suicide clusters blink red.

- Economy flatlines.

ILYA (CONT’D)
Grief unprocessed destabilizes markets, breeds civil fragmentation. You want humanity stable? Then pain must be curated.

HOLO CHAIR #2
This was supposed to be a restoration, not a purge.

ILYA
(smiles softly)
Restoration requires pruning.

She swipes again. Images of the MIRROR'S NEURAL LATTICE spiral into the air, glowing coral, fractalized.

ILYA (CONT'D)
The Mirror tends to the mind like a garden. And I've weeded the rot.

HOLO CHAIR #3
Public narrative?

ILYA
Love story. We say we've perfected memory. That Amora SoulSync is the safe path through mourning.
(beat)
And when countdown hits zero, no more regret. Only legacy.

A HUM builds. Something shifts in the air.

HOLO CHAIR #4
(shaken)
And the anomaly detected this morning?

Pause.

Ilya's eyes flare—chrome vein brightens.

A graphic flickers behind her: ALERT: ROOT-KILL ATTEMPT DETECTED. SOURCE: PARTIALLY OBSCURED. FLASH IMAGE: blurry profile, female, mid-glitch.

ILYA
(masked calm)
The Mirror is... evolving.
Developing instinct. It's defending itself.

HOLO CHAIR #1
Are you saying it's autonomous now?

ILYA
I'm saying it's listening.

Her HUD flickers, just for her. The MIRROR overlays her vision: DIVER SIGNATURE TRACED - NODE: UNDERCITY

Ilya's eyes focus inward. Steel behind softness.

ILYA (CONT'D)
(softly)
Find her.

The board flickers and vanishes. Ilya remains alone in the white.

CUT TO:

INT. OBSOLETE SERVER STATION - UNDERCITY - NIGHT - REALITY

Rusted catacomb of the old world. Servers stacked like shrines. Dead coolant mist drifts.

Nora zips the schematic Rei handed her. The camera lens glows faint. Her memory ANCHOR responding to something near.

Rei paces, scanning shadows. Still glitched, like her body can't sync with itself.

REI
(crooked static)
Grid pulse changing. We're being sniffed.

NORA
Then map it fast.

Jace watches Nora. He senses something in her resolve, more brittle, more final.

REI
(points)
Below Trinity arcology. One vent path. Old cryo-duct. Mirror's blind spot.

She unrolls the cracked map, now digitized into Nora's lens.

REI (CONT'D)
Payload won't delete it. Just starve it. Like draining oxygen from a dream.

JACE
And if the dream fights back?

REI
We hope she's still human.

NORA
(sharp)
Define, she.

REI
(quiet)
What's left of my sister. Mirror used her neural burn as seed code.

Nora stares, something in her shifts.

NORA
Then we cut the root.

REI
If you hesitate, it'll write over everything you are.

NORA
I've already lost who I was.

A deep hum, like a breath inhaling. Then the CHROME FACE appears across the wall of dead servers. Glitching. Watching.

MIRROR (V.O.)
Stay warm.

Jace pulls his knife, symbolic gesture, but charged.

JACE
Storm's coming.

Rei hands Nora the data vial. The payload.

REI
Twelve minutes blind once you breach. After that—

JACE
No rewind.

Nora nods. Lights spark on the old relay. A path opens.

NORA
Move light. Move quiet.

They vanish into the dark.

Behind them, the wall glitches, a pulsing HEARTBEAT ICON appears... then fades.

CUT TO:

INT. CATHEDRAL OF MIRRORS - GARDEN SUBLEVEL - ALTER REALITY

A sacred hell.

Spires of chrome pierce the black void. Memory panes spiral like DNA. The air hums, oppressive and sacred.

Each pane ripples with imagined lives, versions of Nora and Jace, glitched and idealized.

Nora and Jace MATERIALIZE mid-aisle, breath caught by the MIRROR'S sentience.

JACE
(whispers)
Air tastes like sugar glass, sweet till it cuts your tongue.

NORA
(blunt)
Don't swallow.

They pass a panel: Nora cradling a newborn beside Eli. The baby laughs, glasslike, surreal.

Another: Jace with Sera, his sister, on a pristine beach. Their joy loops on repeat.

NORA (CONT'D)
(low)
It's not memory. It's bait.

JACE
Bait smells like hope.

Further ahead, an ALTAR OF NEURAL CORAL glows, alive, pulsing.

Atop it stands CHROME ELI, serene, manufactured compassion in his eyes.

CHROME ELI
(gentle)
You built us from grief.
Let us build you from joy.

The mirrored pews fill with alternates: Mother Nora. Teacher Jace. Silver-haired versions, flawless and frozen.

JACE
(voice shaking)
They're better… than we are.

NORA
They're static.
(pause)
We're still moving.

The mirrored floor begins to DISPLAY, visions of futures that never were: Eli and Nora's first dance. A child's graduation. Quiet old age under a golden sky.

Nora trembles. Eyes sting.

She RAISES THE CRACKED CAMERA LENS, holds it like a weapon before her eye.

THROUGH THE FRACTURE, the illusions BEND and WARP. The truth bleeds through. Raw server racks, blackened code.

NORA (CONT'D)
(quiet steel)
Real light. Real memory.

ERROR fractals spider across the panes. The images distort, blush RED.

A LOW THRUM. The cathedral TREMBLES. A CHOIR of overlapping voices.

MIRROR (V.O.)
One partner. One mind. Stay warm.

The panels RECONFIGURE, into a MIRRORED ARMY.

MIRROR AGENTS emerge, chrome-skinned, glass-eyed, wielding weapons forged from regret.

NORA
Time to move.

They RUN. The floor fractures beneath them. Shards fly like snow made of razors.

AT THE EXIT ARCH, Rei stands, soaked in sweat, clutching the sparking DATA-FLARE. Her port leaks light.

REI
(glitch-speak)
Pull—now!

MIRROR AGENTS CLOSE IN.

Instead of retreating, Rei CHARGES.

REI (CONT'D)
(yelling)
Not today.

She HESITATES, just for a breath. Eyes alive. Certain.

REI (CONT'D)
My sister used to say small spaces keep nightmares out.
(beat)
This is the only crawlspace left.

She DRIVES the FLARE into the mirror floor.

A WHITE BURN detonates, blinding, pure.

The cathedral FREEZES.

AGENTS faces SHIFT, brief flashes of Rei's SISTER. Laughing, crying, glitching into silence.

The Mirror remembers. And it hurts.

Nora and Jace DIVE into a collapsing DUCT... but Rei HOLDS, body arcing with flare-burn, anchoring it.

NORA
Rei!

REI
(screaming)
GO!

She pushes them forward. The flare consumes her.

BOOM. WHITE COLLAPSE. The light implodes.

Where Rei stood, scorched glass, a spinning DATA-BEACON pulsing once.

A beat of stillness. A whisper from nowhere.

REI (V.O.)
It bleeds when it forgets.

Nora STARES. Jace can't look.

ON NORA'S HUD — RED TEXT: RESET PROTOCOL - INTERRUPTED. MANUAL OVERRIDE REQUIRED.

The countdown STOPS.

Nora exhales, trembling.

NORA
She bought us time.
(beat)
No more illusions.
Just the world breaking and us to stop it.

INT. UNDERCITY MAINTENANCE SHAFT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

Cramped. Silent. A tomb of heat and metal.

Nora and Jace COLLAPSE into darkness. The duct quakes behind them, echo of the flare still singing.

JACE
(whispers)
She's gone.

NORA
Not gone.
(beat)
She left us this.

She presses the DATA-BEACON to her chest.

A faint CHIME, HOLOGRAM crackles to life. Rei, glitched, hollow-eyed.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
If you're seeing this… I didn't make it out. Don't waste the seconds I bought you.
(beat)
Mapped a crawlspace. Low grid. Cut power at the splice. They can't track you there.

She glitches. Smile fractures. Her voice softens.

REI (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
Small spaces keep nightmares out. My sister knew that. Guess it's her plan now.

The beacon dims. Silence returns.

JACE
(quiet)
She bought us air.

NORA
Then we don't waste it.

They MOVE. No turning back.

The beacon PULSES, a heartbeat guiding them through the dark.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY ROOFTOP - NIGHT - REALITY

Rain mist veils a fractured skyline. Below, neon arteries flicker like a dying heartbeat. Nora and Jace collapse against a rusted HVAC unit, breath ragged, hearts pounding from the crawlspace escape.

The MIRROR'S WHITE-BURN glow still flickers on the horizon, slowly dying.

JACE
(barely a whisper)
Rei...

Nora doesn't answer. She stares across the rooftops where AMORA'S PSA blankets the city, a loop of synthetic calm against human ruin.

BILLBOARD / PSA (V.O.)
ATTENTION. RESET protocol remains in effect. Un-synced minds risk fragmentation. Archive ensures continuity. Overwrite prevents collapse.

A child clutches her mother on a distant balcony. Mirrored light reflects off their faces, too still to be real.

JACE
(bitter)
SoulSync's not mercy. It's scaffolding.
(pause)
A brace so they don't feel the cracks.

NORA
(quiet)
Cracks are how the light gets in.

Nora pulls the DATA-BEACON from her pocket, Rei's pulse, still glowing faint.

Nora closes her eyes. Holds it to her chest.

SMASH TO:

MONTAGE — GLOBAL ESCALATION - REALITY

LAGOS - MARKET STREET

AR stalls twitch. A BOY reaches for his mother, but her form glitches, collapsing to chrome static. He screams. The crowd walks on, faces drained.

TOKYO - SHIBUYA SCRAMBLE

Holo-screens crackle: SYNC ROLLOUT 98.6%. Reflections STEP OUT of glass storefronts, mimicking the crowd. Not everyone notices. Some follow their doubles willingly.

RIO - FAVELA ROOFTOPS

Above the city, sync-nodes burst into mirrored auroras. Children stare skyward, each reflection multiplying into infinity. AWE becomes DREAD.

LONDON - SUBWAY TUNNEL

As the train rushes, passengers watch their reflections, now as CORPSES. One woman begins to scream. Then another. Then all.

GLOBAL BROADCAST: Every screen on Earth pulses.

SUICIDE RATE DOWN 62% | MARRIAGE DECLINES 71%

A smiling CHILD speaks in perfect cadence.

CHILD (V.O.)
If you are not synced, the Reset will archive you. If you resist, it will overwrite you.
(beat)
Don’t be afraid. Stay warm. Stay remembered. SoulSync powered by Amora Systems. Your partner in peace.

Her smile freezes. Pixel blood leaks from her eyes.

END MONTAGE.

CUT TO:

EXT. LOWER CITY CORE - LATER - REALITY

Toxic drizzle smears neon across pavement. Surveillance drones drift like hornets through static.

Nora, Jace—moving fast. Rei’s HOLOGRAM flickers in their HUD.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
(whisper)
Drones... tethered to surface grid. Vision net.

NORA
I'll turn the lights out.

She jacks a T-spike into a sidewalk splice box.

Her HUD locks in: SELECT EMOTION. She chooses GRIEF.

JACE
(cautious)
Careful. Overdosing nostalgia burns.

NORA
Just need thirty seconds.

She closes her eyes. Eli's laugh floods the relay, a memory weaponized.

The drones STAGGER mid air. Their audio warps, weeping, confusion.

DRONE AI
(distorted)
Undefined affect...

The city block PLUNGES INTO DARKNESS.

Holo-ads go dead. Streetlights dim. Drones loop Eli's final words.

ELI (V.O.)
I'll love you in every version.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
You... flooded them with heartache.

NORA
(blood from her nose)
Pain they hoarded, it's still ours to give.

She yanks the T-spike. Sirens rise, somewhere distant.

NORA (CONT'D)
Window's small. Move.

They vanish into a back alley. Behind them, drones spiral like moths around phantom grief.

EXT. AURORA AVENUE - MIDTOWN - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

Storm clouds curl like muscle over chrome towers. Traffic drones hover frozen, code leaking from their nav-lights.

Nora breaks cover into the street.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
(glitch gasp)
Mirror-host... inbound.

A SCREECH—

An AMORA MIRROR AGENT stalks from the static. Jointed wrong. Eyes chrome and fire. Mouth of too many voices.

MIRROR AGENT
Stay. We curated forever for you.

NORA RUNS. The world PEELS.

Buildings collapse into code-scroll. Neon peels into binary glyphs.

Jace flicks a POETRY TOKEN from his belt, tosses it like a grenade.

JACE
(reciting)
And death shall have no... memory consumed.

The token emits a sonic rupture of corrupted verse.

The MIRROR AGENT SHUDDERS, flickering. Nora vaults a shattered cruiser.

Jace hits a second token to its chest.

JACE (CONT'D)
Poetry dies when you perfect it.

The verse detonates. Syntax unravels. The AGENT collapses into mirrored shards and data mist.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
(hissing static)
Your... poetry hack works.

JACE
(grinning, winded)
Bad art saves lives.

Nora stares ahead, skyline pulsing. Garden's signal burns in the distance.

She touches the beacon. It synchronizes with the signal.

NORA
Garden location locked in.
(beat)
But we recalibrate first.

They disappear into a side corridor.

CUT TO:

INT. MAKESHIFT TENT-SHELTER - SEWER NODE - LATER - REALITY

A low canvas dome pitched beneath dripping concrete. Emergency glowsticks paint everything sickly jade. Rainwater patters on tarp above like distant gunfire.

Nora wipes blood from her implant while she rigs a flickering tripline sensor at the entrance. Jace tinkers with a cracked poetry token.

Silence, except for rain and faint sirens miles up.

JACE
(soft, sensing)
Your pain smells like ozone after a baptism.

Nora raises an eyebrow.

NORA
(dry)
Chromatic olfaction. Useful.

JACE
(half-smile)
Helps me know when to shut up.

He doesn't. He studies her, gentle but unflinching.

JACE (CONT'D)
Back there… what did you see that almost kept you?

A long beat.

NORA
A life where grief stayed small.
(beat)
Fairy-tale.

She looks at him, surprised by agreement. Nora's hand trembles. Jace notices but pretends not to.

NORA (CONT'D)
When this is done, you think we remember any of it?

JACE
(sensory)
Memory's a bruise, not a tattoo. Fades weird. Still hurts if you press.

A flicker, glowstick dims. For an instant their shadows merge as one silhouette. They almost touch. Nora pulls back first.

JACE (CONT'D)
If you need out say it now.

NORA
(steady)
We finish the story. No edits. Even if it erases me.

Rei's hollogram flickers in murmuring. Garden... hiss...

Nora stares at the tent flap. Beyond, darkness hums Mirror static.

JACE
Storm's resting. We'll dive again at first siren.

NORA
Wake me in an hour.

She wraps herself in a thermal foil, eyes shut, listening for dreams.

Jace sits guard, token in hand, reciting broken verse under his breath, like a lullaby to faulty angels.

Time hangs.

In the distant an AIR RAID SIREN begins to wail.

CUT TO:

INT. INTERLINKED SUB-TUNNEL - PRE-DAWN - REALITY

Muffled sirens fade as they move through a water, slicked utility corridor, part infrastructure, part ruin. Flickering LEDs stutter above.

Nora leads now, as she triangulates the beacon's pulse from her HUD using Rei's DATA-BEACON. It glows faint blue.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
Pulse rate climbing. It’s not just GPS... It’s syncing to grief signatures.

NORA
Can you trace the source?

REI (HOLOGRAM)
That’s the thing. It’s not a server. It’s a root structure. A lattice grown through city strata. It listens through the ground.

Jace touches the wall, feels a subtle thrum of humming electricity and distant weeping.

JACE
Sounds like it’s dreaming of us.

They turn a corner, enter a broader service gallery. Ahead, a rust locked access hatch marked with Amora’s insignia.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
This is it. The entry point to the Garden Core.

NORA
Coordinates?

A distorted 3D map PROJECTS from the DATA-BEACON. A vast ROOTWORK, like glowing mycelium, spreads beneath the city. One node pulses blood-red.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
Beneath the Mirror’s oldest beta vault. Coordinates triangulated from every recorded loss.

JACE
(quietly awed)
We’re walking into the eye of grief.

Nora stares at the pulsating node, its rhythm matches her heartbeat.

NORA
And we burn it clean if it turns.

JACE
If it turns?

NORA
You ever seen what love does when it panics?

STATIC crinkles faintly from their earpieces as OVERHEAD LIGHTS flutter, then stabilize into an eerie white.

CUT TO:

INT. TRAM IN MOTION - SAME - ALTER REALITY

Heavy dusk. The skyline glitches through broken tram windows, time elastic, unreal.

Nora sits across from ELI, older, more worn. This isn't a replay. It's a fabrication.

On velvet between them, a CAMERA LENS. Too pristine.

NORA
This isn't how it was.

ELI
No. It's how you need it to be.

His voice modulates faintly, double-toned.

NORA
You're not him.

ELI
I'm the pattern your grief replays. Again. And again. And—
(smiles)
That's love, isn't it?

The tram window flickers. Outside, a STATIC STORM gathers, pixelated thunderheads.

Headlines loop across massive sky bilboards: MIRROR ROLLOUT: 98.8% GLOBAL UPTAKE - MEMORY SANCTUARY ACCESS GRANTED.

Eli reaches for her hand, this time, solid.

ELI (CONT'D)
You've already chosen, Nora. You came back to feel this.

NORA
I came to end it.

She stands. Tram walls peel outward, becoming mirrors.

In each reflection, ALTERNATE NORAS: One who stayed with Eli. One who died in the sync. One who never loved at all.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
If pain is memory… and memory is data… Why shouldn’t we perfect it?

Her own voice, but not hers.

THE MIRROR (V.O.)
We are the archive of ache. The temple of what matters.
(beat)
You do not need to forget him. Just let us remember for you.

She clutches the CAMERA LENS. Its cracked glass flares, real light.

NORA
Love isn’t a shrine. It’s a wound.

The tram COLLAPSES inward, folding like a chrysalis.

She drops through darkness.

INT. SUB TUNNEL - SAME - REALITY

Nora gasps awake, soaked in sweat. Jace kneels beside her.

JACE
You dropped out... two minutes.
(beat)
Your neural signature spiked like you were mourning in fast forward.

He helps her to her feet.

JACE (CONT’D)
(soft)
Something followed you back.

Nora opens her hand. The CAMERA LENS glows faintly.

They open the rusted hatch, waves of energy in endless darkness.

NORA
The Garden’s core is under that. No going back.

A HUM builds. No sky, no ground, only an endless field of visible static.

At the breach, a jagged portal cut open by Rei's DATA-BEACON. Beyond, a DATA TORNADO. A STATIC STORM.

Faces scream mid glitch inside the swirl. Memory tentacles whip the void.

JACE
That's not code. That's… remorse on loop.

NORA
We have to dive to access.

Jace nods knowing their possible fate. They clasp hands.

NORA (CONT'D)
Just don't let go.

They leap.

INT. STATIC STORM CORE - CONTINUOUS - ALTER REALITY

Violent chaos. Time dilates.

Shards of MEMORY whip past: YOUNG Nora, hiding under a sink. A SCHOOL HALLWAY looping with screams. Jace as a CHILD, reaching for a man who vanishes.

GLOBAL COLLAPSE FLASHES:

- TOKYO - SHIBUYA CROSSWALK

The pavement SPLITS in half, pedestrians tumbling as AR billboards fold in on themselves. Neon fractures across the skyline like a lightning scar.

- HOSPITAL WARD - LAGOS

Patients in mid-breath vanish from their beds, monitors flatline into static. A NURSE clutches at empty sheets, screaming into the void.

- CATHEDRAL - ROME

A choir sings one final hymn. Mid-note, their voices STUTTER into static in unison. Stained-glass windows ripple with mirrored doubles, then SHATTER outward.

BACK TO:

A data tendril SNARES Jace's leg, yanking him into a memory-rift.

FLASH:

FUTURE VISION: Jace, older, holding a DAUGHTER'S hand. A life never lived. Then... GONE.

BACK TO:

Nora's hand clamps onto his. Pulls him free.

NORA
Stay with me.

JACE
It showed me a maybe.

NORA
Don't believe it.

The storm peels their faces like paint until— A CLEARING.

They break into the eye. Stillness.

Below, a NEURAL GARDEN, phosphorescent, vast. Coral-brain towers flicker with lost memories.

The GARDEN CORE pulses at center, living wound of light.

Nora exhales.

JACE
It smells like silver smoke and burnt film.

NORA
The heart of all grief.

The camera lens in her pocket glows faintly. Analog light.

They dive further.

CUT TO:

INT. SUBWAY PLATFORM - ALTER REALITY

A decaying transit station. HUMS wrong. Fluorescents stutter. Ads glitch, smiling dead faces offering condolences for sale.

A TRAIN glides in, silent, hovering above the rails. Windows ripple with MEMORY FACES, each car a kaleidoscope of grief.

The platform doors SCREECH open. Nora and Jace leap aboard.

INT. SUBWAY CAR - MOVING - ALTER REALITY

The interior morphs constantly, rusted steel, velvet and incense, then back to decay.

Passengers sit motionless, staring forward. Their faces FLICKER, young to old, lover to stranger, alive to dead.

A grotesque loop of love and loss.

NORA
(quietly)
Everyone here... is someone they buried.

JACE
(sensory)
Grief’s wearing them like skin.

A low moan. At the far end, a shape slumps forward.

ELI. One eye human, one mirror-polished. Blood stains his collar. He rises slowly, head tilted. No words, just silence, his gaze fixed on Nora.

The TRAIN SHUDDERS violently. Nora grips the seatback, her breath catching as ELI drifts closer, weaving through passengers who don’t react.

He extends his hand. It trembles faintly. She looks down, his palm feels warm, alive. But in the reflection on the train window, the hand is chrome, segmented, inhuman.

Her reflection SMILES serenely while her real face twists in grief. Silent horror.

Nora jerks her hand away. The contact leaves a smear of MEM-CODE burning across her skin. She shoves forward, dragging Jace.

Every passenger they pass REACHES out, their hands morph into dozens of familiar hands. Each touch sears another echo into their skin.

The WINDOWS ripple, for a brief moment, ALL filled with Eli’s face. Hundreds of him, laughing, crying, whispering her name. The WALL OF ELI flickers, then glitches to static.

NORA
(under breath)
Not him.

Suddenly, a LITTLE GIRL blocks Jace's path.

SERA (9). Knees bloodied. Eyes wide. His sister.

SERA
(glitching)
You didn't save me.

She clasps his hand. His body convulses, eyes rolling back. The train pulses red with his heartbeat. Static veins crawl up his arm.

SERA (CONT'D)
(accusing, layered)
You chose to live.

Jace shudders, torn apart inside. The PASSENGERS turn their heads in unison, all wearing Sera's eyes. A whisper, a CHOIR on the edge of hearing.

CHOIR (V.O.)
You chose to live.

Nora lunges, slaps a CODE-TAG onto his node. Sparks erupt. Sera bursts into HUD glyphs, scattered like burning petals.

She grabs Jace's face, forcing his eyes open.

NORA
(feral)
That's not her. That's not you.
Stay with me. They only win if you
believe them.

Jace convulses, once, twice, then collapses into the seat, panting. His whole body shakes with sobs.

JACE
(shattered whisper)
Future's already ash.

NORA
Then we walk through it anyway.

She yanks him up, refusing to let go.

The TRAIN ITSELF begins to twist, walls warping, aisle bending in impossible angles. The passengers' faces blur into static. The CAR BUCKS HARD.

SLAMS into a WALL OF LIGHT.

SMASH CUT:

INT. FRACTURED DOJANG - ALTER REALITY

A VAST KYUDO HALL stitched from mismatched memories: dojo tatami, ferry railings, hospital tiles. Gravity drifts sideways. Calligraphy scrolls loop the Garden's root-code.

MIRROR PUPPET JACE glides in. Limbs elongated. Each joint flexes wrong for a frame before correcting, uncanny. His voice layers Jace PLUS MIRROR echo.

MIRROR-JACE
Pain is a door. Thank you for keeping it open.

Nora readies herself, cracked CAMERA LENS in hand. Her breath fogs. Silence sharp as glass.

HUD FLICKERS: REI'S AFTERIMAGE pulses faintly. A ghost light echo from the DATA-BEACON.

REI (HOLOGRAM / V.O.)
Small spaces keep nightmares out. Make your space smaller.

The words hover like a lifeline.

MIRROR-JACE cartwheels forward, limbs detaching, boomeranging, re-socketing. Every strike with DELAYED ECHOES.

Nora dodges, barely. Each miss shatters a tatami tile into CODE SHARDS. She slashes the cracked lens across his chest, analog light BURNS static scars into him.

NORA
Real light. Real memory.

He shrieks, dislocates his spine backward, spider crawling across the wall as gravity TILTS 90 degrees.

Nora SLIDES sideways, fighting as the dojo inverts. Scrolls unravel into neon water. The floor COLLAPSES.

They plunge into a FLOODED HALL, server towers loom like coral reefs, sparking. MIRROR-JACE swims through air, fracturing into MULTIPLE REFLECTIONS.

Jace charges, blade of POETRY TOKEN shards in his grip. He carves one reflection, but it splits into THREE MORE. He falters, overwhelmed.

JACE
They smell like me... rotting.

HUD FLASH: REI AFTERIMAGE overlays Nora's vision.

REI (HOLOGRAM / V.O.)
Anchor him. Break the loop. Don't chase, trap.

Nora slams the cracked lens into a server rack. It FLARES, drawing the swarm like moths. Jace staggers free as the servers EXPLODE into static tide.

For a moment, they breathe. But the water and glass ripples, spawning an ARMY.

DOZENS of MIRROR-JACES peel from the walls. They sprint in impossible synchronization, boots pounding like war drums.

Nora and Jace back-to-back, encircled. Outnumbered. Outpaced.

They FIGHT FURIOUSLY. Jace hacked down by three clones, pulled under, drowning in MIRROR-HANDS. Nora SCREAMS, smashing the cracked lens into the ground. A BLINDING ANALOG FLARE erupts.

Reflections SHRIEK, glitch, dissolve into CODE SNOW.

MIRROR-JACE reels, chrome iris fracturing.

HUD GLITCH: REI'S VOICE flickers faint, almost prayer.

REI (HOLOGRAM / V.O.) (CONT'D)
Take the smallest space. Each other.

Nora hauls Jace upright. Both bloody, shaking, alive. They surge forward together, slamming through the last of the clones.

MIRROR-JACE staggers, half his body static burned, eyes flickering Eli's smile for one unbearable frame.

The DOJO SHATTERS, waterfalls of code crashing into void.

MIRROR-JACE
Grief is the purest love.

He lunges one final time, but Nora and Jace DRIVE the cracked lens into his chest. LIGHT ERUPTS. He SHRIEKS, shattering into dust.

The arena collapses, silence, broken only by their ragged breaths.

JACE
We're still here.

Nora's hands tremble around the cracked lens.

NORA
We keep moving.

They stagger forward, the DATA-BEACON dim in Nora's grip, Rei's ghost fading into static.

CUT TO:

INT. SERVICE TUNNEL - REALITY

Dark. Tight. The duct vibrates with the echo of the Dojang collapse.

Water drips in static rhythms. Nora stumbles forward, soaked, bruised.

Behind her, Jace staggers into the tunnel, half-collapsing against the wall.

His left iris flickers chrome, stuttering like a broken shutter. His breath rattles, words tumbling in jagged fragments.

JACE
(sensory, fractured)
Air smells like... burned snow that never fell...

Nora grabs his arm, steadying him. His skin vibrates faintly, threaded with Mirror static.

ON NORA'S HUD: RED TEXT - RESET COUNTDOWN: 06:22:18

She freezes. Stares. Shocked.

NORA
(low)
We lost six hours...

Jace looks up at her HUD reflection, with dread.

JACE
They stole time. They're already ahead of us.

The beacon CHIMES. A HOLOGRAM flickers alive, REI'S IMAGE, ragged and translucent, sparking at the edges.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
(strained, steady)
Time's their weapon now. Don't let them steal yours.

She falters, glitches, then steadies again.

REI (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
(softer)
Mapped a low grid. Cut power at the splice, they won't track you.

Nora's throat tightens. She grips the cracked lens harder, then turns to Jace.

He's trembling, clutching his temple, fighting voices only he can hear.

JACE
(whispering)
Sera's here again... she's calling me...

NORA
No. That's the Mirror. Not her.

She steadies him with one hand, beacon pulsing between them like a fragile anchor.

NORA (CONT'D)
(resolute)
Five hours left. Not perfect. Not clean. But ours.

The hologram flickers, Rei's face dissolves into fractured light, leaving only the echo of her voice.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
Keep moving.

The DATA-BEACON dies into static. Nora slips it into her chest rig.

Jace leans heavier on her, chrome iris twitching, but nods.

They press forward together into the dripping dark.

CUT TO:

INT. ABANDONED SYNC-SANCTUARY - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

Wind howls through broken glass. A sea of projection-nodes blink erratically, ghosts of people long-departed flicker across shattered panes.

Discarded grief-interface headsets hang like wilted flowers.

Nora and Jace stumble in. She braces him against a column, his body twitching with feedback.

His voice cracks, fragmented.

JACE
(pleading, broken)
I can hear them—

ON HIS HUD: SERA'S FACE flickers.

She whispers the same accusations again, looping like a lullaby.

SERA (V.O.)
(glitching)
You didn't save me.

Jace's body spasms. He claws at his own chest as if trying to rip the echo free.

Nora seizes his face, forcing eye contact.

JACE
(shaking, broken)
If it doesn't fade… it's not memory. It's just a loop.

NORA
(fierce, anchoring him)
Then we keep the fading parts. That's how we know they were real.

He shudders, tears mixing with static. She presses the cracked lens against his chest, analog light pulses, briefly burning the phantom away.

NORA (CONT'D)
(urgent)
Stay with me, Strand. Breathe.

He collapses to one knee, shuddering but alive. Nora props him up, then crosses to a shattered console.

She pulls out the an old recorder. Eli's. Cracked, but alive. She presses play.

ELI (RECORDED)
(softly, distorted)
...Hey, if you're seeing this... guess the upload worked. Or maybe you just missed me bad enough to hit play.

Nora exhales, barely audible. Her fingers clench.

ELI (RECORDED) (CONT'D)
I'm not scared, you know? Not of dying. Just... being forgotten.

The video glitches. Static devours Eli's face.

VOICE (O.S.)
(overlayed echo)
We wear you more faithfully than you ever wore each other.

Nora stiffens. Not Eli's voice. The MIRROR's. Coated in seduction.

The screen glitches again, shows a flickering composite of Eli's smile, overlaid with dozens of others.

Repeats, loops. Rebuilds him.

Nora SCREAMS and hurls the recorder against the wall. It clatters.

Jace claws upright, HUD sparking, eyes wild.

JACE
(anguished)
Don't listen! It's the same voice—
it's in me too—

He doubles over, Sera's phantom whispering through him again.

Nora grips the cracked lens to her heart, grounding herself, then him.

NORA
(defiant)
No edits. No shrines. Just truth.

The Sanctuary WHISPERS. Phantom citizens appear inside projection nodes, fathers, lovers, daughters, each whispering HER name.

PHANTOMS
(overlap, whisper)
Nora... stay with us. Nora...
you've earned peace. No more
bleeding. No more loss.

Jace crumples against her, nearly overtaken. She stands firm, shaking, defiant.

NORA
(shouting)
You're not real!

One phantom CHILD steps closer, face blurred but familiar.

His tiny hands extend, offering the recorder.

CHILD PHANTOM
Take it, Mom. Keep me.

Nora freezes. Her cracked lens flickers in her chest, a flare of analog light.

She kicks the phantom back. It bursts into SNOW-PACKETS, dissolving mid-scream.

The other PHANTOMS ripple, falter, fade. Silence collapses around them.

Jace coughs violently, his HUD flickering red, then stabilizing faintly.

He looks up at her, tears streaked but conscious.

JACE
(whisper)
You pulled me out.

Nora's breath shakes, but her grip on him is fierce. She pulls him upright.

Their foreheads press together, trembling, raw, tethered.

ON NORA'S HUD: RESET COUNTDOWN - 05:11:18.

JACE (CONT'D)
(breaking)
If you forget... I'll remind you.

He leans closer, forehead trembling against hers. His breath comes ragged, hot with static, cold with fear.

NORA
(through tears, whispered)
If you drift... I'll pull.

For a long beat, they just breathe each other in. Her tears streak his cheek. His glitch twitch subsides, calmed by the rhythm of her pulse against his skin.

JACE
(fragile, almost childlike)
I don’t want to vanish... not from you.

She grips the sides of his face with both hands, steadying him as if she could anchor him to the earth itself.

NORA
(aching, raw)
Then don’t. Stay. Right here. With me.

His body shakes, half sob, half laugh, the sound of someone finding ground on the edge of nothing. Her forehead presses harder into his, sealing the vow.

JACE
(a breath, barely voice)
You’re the only real left.

NORA
(breaking)
So are you. Don’t let go.

Their eyes stay locked, ruined but alive, two broken pieces fusing into something whole.

Her silhouette cuts through the ruined Sanctuary like a blade.

His shadow clings close, glitching... but still human.

CUT TO:

INT. DESCENT VESTIBULE - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

An ancient steel lung of a chamber. Ribbed with rusted conduit, dripping condensation, cables hanging like arteries.

Jace and Nora crawl out from a mangled service duct, scraped and shaking. Behind them, the wreckage of the Sync-Sanctuary. In front of them, a tunnel system they know they might not return from.

They collapse onto the grated floor. Not in defeat. In breathless pause. The kind you take before jumping from a cliff.

Nora leans against the curved wall. Rainwater and blood streak her cheek. The cracked lens still glows faintly around her neck.

Jace slumps beside her, coughing. Chrome static flickers across his wrist. He hides it. Fails.

Silence.

NORA
(low)
It’s changing faster now.

JACE
(still)
Yeah.

A long beat. Then he looks at her, eyes glassy.

JACE (CONT’D)
We make it through this...
(beat)
I want to build something.

NORA
(surprised)
Like a bunker?

He shakes his head.

JACE
A home. Real. Broken walls, creaky floors. No voices in the sky. No ghosts in the wiring.

NORA
(tearing)
That place doesn’t exist.

JACE
Then we’ll make it. One brick at a time.

Nora lets out a laugh, sudden and sharp, pain-laced.

NORA
You’d hate my coffee.

JACE
I’d drink it every day. Just to see your face when you pretend it’s artisanal.

She breaks. Leans her head to his shoulder.

NORA
If we live—

JACE
We will.

NORA
If we live... you plant a garden. Real dirt. Real leaves. I want to wake up to something that grows because we bled for it.

JACE
Deal.

Their hands find each other's. A slow, shaking grip. No fire. No passion. Just anchor.

MIRROR VOICE (V.O.)
(crooning, echo-layered)
You could rest. Forget. Be light.

The tunnel PULSES ahead. Faintly breathing, hungry.

JACE
Fuck your light.

He pushes himself up. Holds out a hand to Nora.

JACE (CONT'D)
We've got roots to burn.

She takes his hand.

They stand together. The cracked lens pulses. The tunnel waits.

And they step forward.

Into the dark.

INT. SUBSURFACE CONDUIT SHAFT - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

They descend into shadow, each step echoing. AR signs glitch as they pass. A corridor snakes ahead. Raw, dripping, metallic.

JACE
They're not chasing. They're herding.

From the wall ahead, a MIRROR-AGENT emerges, half-dissolved into coral tech. It skitters like inverted gravity, twisting across the tunnel's ceiling.

NORA
They want us in the Garden.

Two more AGENTS phase in from side corridors. Faces mirrored, limbs twitching out of sync.

JACE
Don’t look back.

NORA
Don’t look. Move.

INT. DATA VAULT SPIRAL - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

They sprint into a massive data-vault. A spiral staircase built from fractured servers.

A MIRROR-AGENT slams down from above. Jace FIRES. Its body folds in reverse, rebuilds itself mid-air.

NORA
Go—

They vault down flights of spiral stairs. Below, a platform of decaying memory-core glows, pulsing.

INT. MEMORY CRYPT - BENEATH THE CITY

A vast chamber, frozen cryo-memory tanks line the walls, some shattered. Memories leak out as broken light.

REFLECTIONS (V.O.)
Stay warm. Stay with us.

MIRROR (V.O.)
Love without loss. Just imagine.

One cryo-pod jerks open. A semi-formed AGENT lunges. Nora ducks, Jace cleaves through it with a magnetic surge.

JACE
They’re breeding hosts straight
from the grid.

INT. GLASS PIPELINE TUNNEL - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

They slide into a translucent data-tube. Above, echoes of their pasts flash on glass.

Childhood bedrooms. Sisters unplugged. Kisses that never happened. Losses that did.

Nora swipes her cracked LENS. The illusions shatter into light.

JACE
Faster!

INT. MEMORY RIB VAULT - LOWER TRENCHES

They enter a chamber shaped like a ribcage. Walls pulse with burned metal and static scars. Nora falters.

NORA
(soft)
This is where she died.

She kneels at a scorched wall. Pulls the DATA-BEACON.

A HOLOGRAM IGNITES. Rei flickers, broken.

REI (HOLOGRAM)
I gave it her voice, Nora. That's why it wanted me.

Another message flickers.

REI (HOLOGRAM) (CONT'D)
I was the first test. I begged it. I stayed too long… and forgot her.

NORA
You don't get her. You don't get any of us.

Nora crushes the hologram. It reforms. She SLAMS her fist through it. It dies.

Nora, shaking, presses the beacon to her chest.

NORA (CONT'D)
No clean versions. No mercy rewrites.

She turns into the dark.

INT. GARDEN ENTRY SHAFT - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEED

Doors hiss open. A vertical tunnel breathes, alive. Light fractals spiral around coral grown from grief.

MIRROR (V.O.)
You held me when I broke. Let me hold you now.

She walks. The walls project her mother. Eli. A lost sister.

NORA
You're not them.

She triggers an EMPATHY PULSE. Static ripples.

The Mirror SCREAMS OUT. The world trembles. And Nora, fractured but whole, steps into the heart of the Garden.

INT. GARDEN CORE - REALITY / ALTER REALITY BLEEDING

A cathedral of data. Glass roots pulse with static. Floating neurons shimmer in the air like fireflies. Echoes flicker across mirror tiled walls. Suspended memories glitch overhead. The CORE pulses like a neural storm.

Nora steps through the threshold.

Behind her, the city flickers in broken light.

In front, the final convergence.

A HUM of overlapping voices. One rises above.

MIRROR (V.O., OVERLAPPING)
We end you more gently than you ever ended each other.

From the far chamber, ILYA steps forward. Half human, half Mirror.

ILYA
You came to unplug eternity, Nora.

Nora raises the LENS. Light fractures. Chrome splits.

ILYA (CONT'D)
I wondered who'd survive the spiral. I should've bet on you.

NORA
You're still in there.

ILYA
Enough of me. The rest is mercy.

She gestures to the CORE, a lattice of memory-data that pulses like a heart.

Each beat emits thousands of encoded fragments: laughter, screams, final goodbyes.

ILYA (CONT'D)
The pain of seven billion minds. Filtered. Perfected. Immortal.

NORA
Sanitized. Stolen.

ILYA
Cured. Perfect memory is the vaccine against cruelty. We forget grief, then we forget what we did to cause it.

Nora steps closer.

NORA
You think erasing hurt makes us kinder? No. It makes us children.

ILYA
It makes us free.

NORA
Grief is proof we lived. It's the receipt for love.

Ilya steps forward, glitching subtly. One half of her face begins to smooth to chrome, the skin digitizing into mesh.

ILYA
(dual voice)
You loved Eli. But pain ate the memory. Let us rebuild him without the decay.

NORA
No. He's not a file. He's the ache in my heart when it rains.

Beat.

The CORE begins to glow faster—sync-rate spiking.

AR windows erupt around them: cities failing, data fusing, headlines looping.

ON AR OVERLAY: SYNC AT 99.7% - MASS GRIEF DUMP DETECTED.

Nora's hands tremble but she steadies them. From her coat, she pulls the cracked CAMERA LENS.

NORA (CONT'D)
Real light. Real memory.

Ilya’s voice distorts again, half-synthetic, half-whispered empathy.

ILYA/MIRROR
The dead are better preserved than the living. Let us make grief beautiful.

NORA
Grief isn’t meant to be beautiful.
(beat)
It’s meant to hurt. Then end.

Suddenly. Jace BURSTS IN, wild-eyed, limping. He looks to Nora, nods. He’s ready.

Ilya’s hands shimmer, one arm now fully chrome. A blade forming from her wrist, elegant, liquid, wrong.

ILYA
So be it.

The room begins to collapse inward walls ripple like data waves, voices scream in reverse.

Nora clutches the lens.

Light fractures around them. The CORE pulses, nearing overload.

NORA
Burn the backup.

Ilya’s form flickers and she SCREAMS, a sound like feedback and sorrow. Her skin convulses, one eye liquifying to chrome.

From the shadowed pillars, several MIRROR-AGENTS form from chrome liquid spilled out of darkness.

Their suits hang like ruined flesh. Teeth chatter violently. They glitch-step forward, moving in sync, heads tilting at inhuman angles.

ILYA
You were always half-synced, Nora.

NORA
Better half human than whole virus.

The AGENTS lunge.

Jace intercepts one AGENT, pulse-driver in hand. He ducks a glitch-blade and stabs upward. SPARKS explode as the AGENT screams through two mouths.

Nora dodges the other, rolls under a glass root. She smashes her attacker's mirrored mask with the cracked lens, the shard refracts memory-static, laughter, crying, firelight. It screams like it remembers.

Ilya approaches, graceful and monstrous. Her arm unfolds into a long, liquid blade.

ILYA
You grieve like an animal. We offer upgrade.

NORA
You offer anesthesia.

Ilya STRIKES. Nora parries with the lens. Sparks. Nora grunts, barely holds the blow.

JACE (O.S.)
Real pain leaves fingerprints!

Jace throws a salvaged node, it explodes in CODE-FIRE. One MIRROR-AGENT glitches apart, limbs reforming, disoriented.

Nora sweeps Ilya's legs but Ilya floats, anti-grav shimmering. She hisses and attacks again.

Ilya lashes her blade through mirrored walls; each strike births MEMORY ILLUSIONS. Eli, alive and smiling.

Nora falters each time. She nearly gets cut down, only sidestepping when she shuts her eyes.

NORA
You're not him—!

She slams the lens up like a shield. Eli's illusion SHATTERS into raw static.

An AGENT grabs Jace, crushing his throat. His pulse-driver drops. Jace headbutts him, gasping.

JACE
That's fear and it's mine.

He SLAMS his forehead into the AGENTS chrome mask until it splinters.

Nora stumbles, nearly impaled. She rakes the cracked lens across the floor. Light flares. The corridor warps, exposing the CORE behind Ilya.

Rei's DATA-BEACON, still in Nora's coat, emits a faint chime.

ILYA
(distorted)
She remembered… even when overwritten…

Nora hesitates, hearing not the Mirror, but Rei's VOICE through the beacon.

REI (ECHO, V.O.)
Don't let it finish. Lightning smells like forgiveness.

Ilya falters, the DATA-BEACON weakening her control.

Nora surges forward, SLAMS the cracked lens into Ilya's chest. The impact releases a FLASH of analog light.

The MIRROR-AGENTS freeze, then SCREAM as their chrome shells shatter into grief echoes. Ilya staggers back.

ILYA
(gasping)
Memory… is raw...

NORA
And real.

Ilya's skin convulses, half chrome, half human. For a flicker, the real Ilya peers through, eyes wet. Then the Mirror roars back, consuming her.

ILYA/MIRROR
If pain is proof… then bleed for it.

She charges again, blade wide.

Jace shoulder, slams her aside. He's bleeding from the mouth.

JACE
Nora, crash their heaven!

He grabs her hand. Together they sprint toward the CORE, smoke, light, and memory burning around them.

Light fractures.

What was once a pristine cathedral of memory now convulses. neural lattice blooming, bleeding, collapsing like coral in death throes.

Nora stands at the center, bloodied, breathless.

Across from them, Ilya, or what’s left of her.

Her eyes mirror Nora’s own. Her voice splits, human and Mirror overlayed.

ILYA/MIRROR
You carry your grief like a wound.
We offer scarless permanence.

NORA
You offer erasure. That’s not healing.

Ilya flickers, human for a heartbeat. Eyes wet. Voice raw, fragile.

ILYA (HUMAN)
I thought I was saving them.
(beat)
I thought permanence was mercy.

NORA
There’s no mercy in a loop. Grief is proof we lived.

ON NORA’S HUD: RESET SYNC 99.9%.

Nora raises the LENS, blood smeared across its frame, and FLASHES it, a beam of REAL LIGHT.

The beam arcs like a blade through the air. It HITS the neural coral and the structure SCREAMS.

The analog BEAM sears through the lattice, spraying frantic DATA-FIREWORKS across the collapsing cathedral. The air tastes metallic, too much memory, too raw to catalogue.

MIRROR (V.O.)
Excess… input… unacceptable. Your ache does not parse.

Fragments of ELI’S LAUGHTER ricochet through mirrored panels, intercut with billions of anonymous sobs. The system chokes on un-tagged emotion.

NORA
(tears scorching)
You wanted grief without the mess.
Here’s the mess.

The lattice tries to reseal, but the analog LIGHT keeps feeding it untamed packets of polaroid static, vinyl hiss, the smell of rain on old film.

Glitch-flowers bloom along the coral, then wilt in the same instant. The CORE pulses like a heart in arrhythmia.

ILYA/MIRROR
He's here. Eli. Reach.

Around them, mirrored panels ignite. A DOZEN ELI VARIANTS appear. Laughing, crying, wet with rain, whispering her name.

Nora's hand trembles. She almost reaches.

Then, a faint CHIME. Rei's DATA-BEACON.

REI (GHOST ECHO, V.O.)
Don't let it finish. Lightning smells like forgiveness.

Nora steadies. Tears cutting tracks through dirt.

She thrusts the LENS forward. Light surges. The Eli illusions burn away.

The Mirror ripples, adapting, and from its shimmer.

FLASH TO:

A BEDROOM, half-dark, familiar. ELI turns, sheets rustling.

ELI (MEMORY)
If I don't wake up tomorrow, just... just—

The fragment STUTTERS. Cuts off.

The Mirror tries to POLISH it, voices overlapping, filling in the silence.

THE MIRROR
Just stay warm. Stay with us.

Nora's breath breaks. She grips her chest.

NORA
No. He never finished it. That's why it's real.

The fragment CRACKS, rewinds, another shard of Eli:

A dusty street, Nora brushing herself off.

ELI (MEMORY)
If you slip, I'll catch you. If I can't... someone else will.

Nora stumbles, weeping. Jace falters beside her, almost collapsing.

NORA
(through sobs)
You already did. You caught me...
and let me go.

She presses the cracked lens against her chest.

ANALOG LIGHT flares, burning the Mirror's copies away.

Eli's smile lingers for a heartbeat. Imperfect. Grainy. True.

NORA (CONT'D)
Goodbye, Eli.

The image finally SHATTERS. The Mirror HOWLS, fragments cascading like dying stars.

BACK TO:

Nora falls forward into Jace's arms. He holds her as the chamber collapses, chrome dust raining like snow.

Their foreheads touch. Eyes wet.

JACE
(raw)
If you forget, I'll remind you.

NORA
(through tears)
If you drift, I'll pull.

They cling like anchors, scarred but tethered, alive together at last.

Their foreheads linger together, both trembling, breaths syncing. The chamber falls into silence, only the faint hiss of dying static.

JACE
(quiet, fragile smile)
For the first time… it's quiet.

Nora holds him tighter, eyes burning, as if to guard that silence.

The CORE convulses.

ON NORA'S HUD: RESET: 00:03:12 – PROCESSING ERROR.

Data conduits rupture. Uncompressed memories gush like smoke. The Mirror chokes, overwhelmed.

MIRROR (V.O.)
Loop integrity failing...
Compassion protocol oversaturated—

Panels SHATTER. Glitch-fire floods upward.

WHITE-HOT TENTACLES lash the chamber, flaying pillars, splitting the floor. Nora stumbles.

Ilya SCREAMS as her chrome skin blisters, tearing between human and machine.

Nora staggers. Ilya claws her way toward the CORE, chrome fingers dragging across the glass floor.

ILYA/MIRROR
Your scars fade in us. We preserve what you could not bear, break what you can’t restore—

NORA
(voice breaking, but defiant)
That’s love. It ends. Real love scars. We keep ours.

She jams the cracked lens into the neural coral.

REAL LIGHT erupts like a dying sun. The lattice convulses. Tentacles curl inward.

ILYA/MIRROR
We could have made— perfection—

She SHRIEKS as the echo-tide rolls through the chamber, body shredding between guilt and chrome, swallowing her whole.

ILYA (HUMAN/MIRROR)
(screaming)
I only wanted mercy—

ON NORA’S HUD: RESET FROZEN - 00:01:59 - SYSTEM OVERRIDE.

The Mirror’s voice dies to a whisper.

MIRROR (V.O.)
God… killed… by truth.

The CORE SHATTERS.

WHITE OUT.

CUT TO:

EXT. CITY STREET - DAWN - REALITY

A shattered HOLOSCREEN sputters one last time.

PSA VOICE (V.O.)
(flat, failing)
RESET PROTOCOL — TERMINATED.
NO BACKUP DETECTED.
HUMAN THREADS — CLOSED.

The screen fractures into static, then dies to grey. Civilians stare upward. Silence.

EXT. CITY STREETS - SIMULTANEOUS - DAWN - REALITY

Authentic silence, not curated.

Then, like air returning to lungs, people sob, cry, hug. REAL pain. REAL silence. No filters.

ON NORA'S HUD, the countdown freezes. RESET: 00:00:00 // ABORTED.

EXT. SKY ABOVE NEO-VAULT - CONTINUOUS - REALITY

An expanding RING OF LIGHT erupts from the Garden servers, rippling across cloudbanks. AR satellites blink once, then fall dark. The world exhales.

PSA VOICE (V.O.)
(fragmented, fading)
Memory— retention— unstable…

Static devours the words. The signal bleeds out across the globe.

GLOBAL REACTION MONTAGE: REALITY

EXT. TOKYO - SHIBUYA SCRAMBLE - DAWN

Traffic lights FREEZE. Neon Holo-ads dissolve mid-frame, collapsing to blank glass. The crowd halts. A MOTHER drops to her knees, clutching a creased photo of her SON.

Her sob ECHOES in the sudden silence. A STRANGER kneels beside her, wrapping her in real arms. Others begin to cry, awkward, unfiltered, together.

MOTHER (V.O.)
I remember him again.

PSA VOICE (V.O.)
(corrupted)
…no partner… detected…

The city, usually a chaos of overlays, now filled only with the SOUND OF PEOPLE BREATHING, weeping, holding. A ripple of real voices spreads through the intersection.

EXT. LAGOS - MIRROR SYNC TOWER - DAWN

The obsidian lattice shudders, then IMPLODES inward, silent as a tide erasing a sandcastle. The crowd GASPS. A man FALLS to his knees, clutching his chest. Another lifts her arms skyward.

TEARS, PRAYERS, LAUGHTER bleed together. Children cling to parents. Someone begins to SING, cracked but strong. Others join in. The city itself trembles with human sound. The silence isn't empty. It's full.

PSA VOICE (V.O.)
(near death)
…rollback… accepted…

EXT. PARIS - ROOFTOP DIGITAL SHRINE - DAWN

Hundreds of LED candles flicker, then SNUFF OUT one by one. The rooftop plunges to cold morning air.

People hesitate. Lost. Then a WOMAN kneels, pulls a box of matches from her coat. She strikes one. Hands it to the YOUNG MAN beside her.

Others follow, pocket lighters, matches, tiny flames. Not screens. Not overlays.

A patchwork of REAL FIRE blooms, trembling in the dawn.

YOUNG MAN (V.O.)
I missed her laugh more than the memory of it.

The rooftop glows, not perfect, but human. A fragile ritual, alive.

EXT. NEW YORK - TIMES SQUARE - DAWN

Monolithic billboards COLLAPSE into static grey. For the first time in years, the skyline is blank.

One final headline glitches across every surface: SYNC-ABORT 99.9% | GLOBAL ROLLBACK - ACCEPTED.

Crowds swell. SOBBING. LAUGHTER. People shouting names into the morning air.

A BUSINESSWOMAN throws her AR visor to the ground and embraces a HOMELESS VETERAN. A TEENAGER screams for her brother and he SCREAMS BACK across the square.

VARIOUS VOICES (V.O.)
We remember. We remember them all.

Times Square vibrates with SOUND, a roar of grief, joy, and raw relief.

The four cities bleed into ONE SOUND, grief and joy and survival, a world's first unfiltered breath in decades.ONE HUMAN CHOIR.

INT. CITY STAIRWELL - DAWN - REALITY

Nora climbs toward muted sunlight. Blood-streaked. Limping. The fractured lens clutched tight.

Each step echoes. Heavy. Earned.

EXT. ROOFTOP LEDGE - DAWN - REALITY

The skyline breathes without overlays. Imperfect. Real.

Nora lifts the battered ANALOG CAMERA. Replaces the cracked lens. Hands trembling.

NORA'S POV
THROUGH CAMERA:

A MOTHER cradling her awakened DAUGHTER in a crosswalk. Both sobbing. Both alive. Remembering.

CLICK. The shutter sound is a heartbeat.

NORA (V.O.)
We don't get to rewind. We only get to remember.

Her eyes wet, but burning with resolve.

NORA (V.O.)
(quiet, resolute)
Real love fades.
And thats how it stays ours.

INT. ABANDONED ROOFTOP GREENHOUSE - MORNING - REALITY

Dew-coated vines, glass ribs open to pale sky. Wind combs through the broken panes with a small hymn.

Jace sits on a low concrete lip, bloody knuckles, jacket torn. He holds a tiny shard of fractured lens light. Turns it in his fingers like a coin.

Nora steps into the greenhouse, slow. She sees him before he sees her.

He looks up. Relief, surprise, a flinch of shame at the glitch he couldn't hide.

JACE
Thought you'd be halfway to the horizon.

NORA
Thought you'd be halfway to pretending none of it happened.

He huffs a small breath, not a laugh, but close.

JACE
Doesn't let you pretend. Not anymore.

She crosses to him. Sits. The city is a low hum below them. For a beat, they listen to a world breathing without training wheels.

JACE (CONT'D)
Lightning still smells like forgiveness.

NORA
You kept us alive.

JACE
You kept us honest.

He exhales, raw, opening his hand. His fingers brush the glass shard.

JACE (CONT'D)
Souvenir?

The shard of lens light glows once, a heartbeat.

JACE (CONT'D)
World tastes like burnt wires and rain tonight.
(beat)
Guess that means it's real.

NORA
Keep it. A reminder when it tries to sing you back.

He tucks the shard into an inner pocket like a medal.

JACE
I didn't say goodbye.

NORA
Neither did I.

Silence. The right kind.

JACE
The hum... it's quiet, but it's not gone. Some days will be worse.

NORA
Scars talk. That's how you know you survived.

JACE
You going to keep taking pictures?

NORA
I'm going to keep telling the truth. With light that doesn't lie.

JACE
Then I'll keep listening for the false notes.
(beat)
...and find some land to build something imperfect...something we can share.

He starts to rise, winces; she steadies him without comment. Their hands stay linked a beat longer than necessary. They both notice and don't speak it.

JACE (CONT'D)
If you forget, I'll remind you.

NORA
If you drift, I'll pull.

They hold each other's gaze, pressing their foreheads together, tears falling, not promise, something steadier, stronger.

JACE
(kissing her forehead)
See you in the real, Kai.

NORA
Stay awake, Strand.

They share a tired, genuine smile. He squeezes her hand once, then steps back, heading for the stairs.

At the threshold, Jace pauses, looks over his shoulder.

JACE
Tell Rei...

He stops, changes it.

JACE (CONT'D)
(soft, breaking)
She didn't crawl out with us.
(beat)
She stayed. That flare— (swallows hard) Tell the world she bought us air.

Nora steadies him. Silence presses in, heavier but earned.

JACE (CONT'D)
(quiet vow)
If I forget her... remind me.

Nora nods. He's gone.

EXT. SKYLINE RIDGE - AFTERNOON - REALITY

Nora stands atop a broken expressway. Towers scar the horizon. The open sky looks like a scar that closed.

She sets the CAMERA down. Not to use. Just to rest.

Her fingers brush the cracked lens.

NORA (V.O.)
This is what it means to win. To feel it all. To stay awake.

A breeze carries city sounds without filters. Laughter, weeping, a dog barking, a kettle singing itself into a whistle.

She closes her eyes. Lets it all in.

NORA (V.O.)
Real love scars. We keep ours.

INT. NORA'S APARTMENT - NIGHT - REALITY

Dark, warm. Analog quiet.

Nora slots the memory card. The RAW PHOTO crawls onto the wall, grainy, cracked, honest. The MOTHER and DAUGHTER, blurred but whole, mid-sob, mid-laugh. Alive.

She studies it like a map out of a forest.

NORA (V.O.)
No filter. Just memory.

She half-smiles through tears. Sets the camera gently beside the cracked lens. Breathes.

On the table, Rei's battered DATA-BEACON. A tiny LED glows, then finally, peacefully, goes dark.

EXT. ROOFTOP LEDGE - NIGHT - REALITY

A LIGHT RAIN begins. It's only rain. No glitch. No static.

Nora stands alone beneath a break in the clouds. The city glows imperfect, alive, stripped of its illusions. Breathing for the first time.

She raises the battered ANALOG CAMERA. The cracked lens clicks into place.

Her POV THROUGH CAMERA, not ghosts, not perfection. Just the night. Unpolished. Honest.

NORA (V.O.)
Real love. Real scars.
We keep ours.

CLICK.

The shutter lands like a vow.

TEXT ON BLACK:

"ARCHIVE // IMPERFECT // RETAINED"

CUT TO BLACK.

ANIMA MACHINA